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INSIDE



**West Bengal  
polls: BJP spent  
₹286.99 crore**

**NEW DELHI**  
The BJP spent ₹286.99 crore on West Bengal Assembly polls, which is more than half of the total of ₹529.38 crore the party spent on the recent Assembly polls in four States and one UT, as per expenditure statements filed with the Election Commission. » PAGE 5



**'Homemaker' a  
gender-neutral  
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**MADURAI**  
"If there can be housewives, there can be house husbands also. Let this become a new normal. We are of the view this would help preserve institution of marriage and family. The expression 'homemaker' is gender-neutral," the Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court has said. » PAGE 3

**Centre reduces  
import duty  
on edible oils**

**NEW DELHI**  
The Centre on Thursday reduced the Basic Customs Duty on major imported crude edible oils, including palm oil. A statement from the Union Food and Consumer Affairs Ministry said the decision was taken to moderate domestic edible oil prices, provide relief to consumers, and mitigate "inflationary pressures" from "sharp increase in international edible oil prices". » PAGE 6

# Polls rigged, CEC must quit immediately: Rahul

Prime Minister, Union Home Minister are 'at the top of this conspiracy, says the Opposition leader

CEC should turn an approver in the alleged 'vote chori' issue as an 'act of nationalism', adds Rahul

Those who 'played' with the democratic process of polls were committing treason, says Priyanka

**Sandeep Phukan**  
NEW DELHI

Elections in India are being rigged, and Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union Home Minister Amit Shah, and Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar acted as "deshdrohis" (traitors) by destroying the country's votes, Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi alleged on Thursday while demanding the immediate resignation of the poll official.

Speaking at a press conference here, the Congress leader said the CEC should turn an approver in the alleged 'vote chori' issue, as that would be an "act of nationalism". The press conference came a day after *The Indian Express* reported that two Election Commissioners had major differences with the CEC and they formally objected 14

times in 10 months to decisions made in the name of the poll body.

"If tomorrow the BJP sweeps the national election, India will not believe it. So now we are heading to the point where public expression will not allow the BJP to get the type of majority they were getting," Mr. Gandhi told *The Hindu* in response to a question on the Opposition's option.

Mr. Gandhi appreciated the dissent registered by the two ECs but asserted that it started after he had already held several press conferences.

"They are, in a way, saying that the vote does not exist in India anymore," he said.

**'Attack on the nation'**  
He said the alleged manipulation of elections is an attack on the nation, and Mr. Modi and Mr. Shah would be investigated for what



Rahul Gandhi addresses the media at the party's headquarters in New Delhi on Thursday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

they have done to the country.

"If the vote is destroyed, the Constitution is not functioning, laws are illegal, institutions mean nothing," Mr. Gandhi said, adding, "I have shown it with proof, and let me tell you, there is already more than enough information to make this 100% certain – not 99%, 100% certain –

that Indian elections, Lok Sabha elections, the 2024 election, Vidhan Sabha elections, are all being rigged."

The Congress Working Committee would meet on September 29 to discuss the way forward for the principal Opposition party on the issue of alleged 'vote chori'.

Wayanad MP Priyanka

**CJP asks Kumar  
to quit, warns of  
nationwide stir**

**NEW DELHI**  
The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) on Thursday demanded the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar for "undermining" voter rights through the SIR of poll rolls and warned of a nationwide agitation if he does not step down in 48 hours. » PAGE 5

**Five Left parties  
announce protest  
against CEC, SIR**

**NEW DELHI**  
In a joint statement, five Left parties have announced a week-long protest across the country from Saturday till October 2 demanding the ouster of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar and a halt to the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. » PAGE 5

why should the CEC have any protection against it?" Ms. Vadra asked.

"If he [CEC] has done an illegal act, he has been fully aware that this is happening under his nose, his colleagues have brought it to his attention, he has ignored it and intentionally allowed an unfair election to take place. He should be criminally prosecuted just like any other criminal, and he should be tried for treason," she said.

Mr. Gandhi claimed that since 1947, India has never found itself in a situation where the election system has been "fundamentally broken".

"Without any doubt, both the Prime Minister and Amit Shah are at the top of this conspiracy, and they are going to be investigated for what they have done to this country. This is an act against the Indian state. This is an act against India's people," he said.

elections was committing "treason" against the nation. "That is our clear stand. I do not think anybody in that position should have legal protection in the way that the CEC has, if they have done illegal acts," she said.

"Since criminal acts fall under a particular law, and people are usually tried and prosecuted for them,

## Xi calls for peace as he gets a grand welcome in the U.S.

**Agence France-Presse**  
WASHINGTON

Xi Jinping told Donald Trump on Thursday that Beijing and Washington must peacefully manage their superpower rivalry, as the U.S. President gave his Chinese counterpart a lavish welcome to the White House. While Mr. Trump hailed their "truly great friendship" on a day of sweeping pomp and circumstance, Mr. Xi used his state visit to lay down China's red lines on AI, Taiwan and the Iran war.

The talks were focused on tensions that continue to divide the world's two largest economies. In his opening remarks with Mr. Trump, Mr. Xi said the two countries must ensure there is "no conflict and no confrontation between us." Mr. Xi also warned that the development of artificial intelligence should be "always under human control" – in contrast to Mr. Trump, who has repeatedly dismissed warnings that AI could threaten humanity itself.

Mr. Trump's remarks struck a warmer tone, underscoring the U.S. President's long-term efforts to woo the Chinese leader.

"President Xi and I have made tremendous strides on the issues facing our two countries," Mr. Trump said after greeting Xi for his first visit to the White House in over a decade.

The 80-year-old Mr. Trump said that the pair would "discuss pressing issues concerning security, technology, and super intelligence – SI," his name for artificial intelligence.

But later as they met in the Oval Office, Mr. Xi urged Mr. Trump to show "prudence" and oppose in-



**A balancing act:** U.S. President Donald Trump with Chinese President Xi Jinping in the White House Oval Office on Thursday. AP

dependence for the flash-point of Taiwan, the self-governing island that Beijing claims.

The Chinese leader – whose country has reportedly shared intelligence with Tehran – also urged Mr. Trump to end the Iran war "through negotiation as soon as possible."

**Points of friction**  
Few breakthroughs are expected during Mr. Xi's state visit. Instead the trip is more about the spectacle as the world's two biggest economies seek manage points of friction.

A formal welcome on the White House South Lawn launched Thursday's events, before Mr. Trump and Mr. Xi inspected a military parade on the newly paved-over Rose Garden.

American military jets – including a B-2 bomber of the type that bombed Iranian nuclear facilities last year – then staged a flyover as U.S. and Chinese flags flew over the West Wing.

Mr. Trump later walked Mr. Xi out to see the new helipad he has built at the White House, and took the Chinese leader aboard his helicopter – one of the most exclusive and sensitive pieces of U.S. military equipment.

"We had a great meeting," Mr. Trump said, as

the pair ignored questions on subjects including Iran, Taiwan, fentanyl trafficking and jailed Hong Kong pro-democracy media mogul Jimmy Lai.

Mr. Trump added that Mr. Xi was an "expert on stone aside from many other things and he loves good granite," referring to the material used for the helipad, which he has boasted will last a million years.

Mr. Trump will later throw a state dinner for Mr. Xi attended by top U.S. tech CEOs. The charm offensive began Wednesday as Mr. Trump personally greeted Mr. Xi at the airport – the first time in more than six decades that a U.S. President welcomed a foreign head of state in person at Joint Base Andrews near Washington.

Mr. Trump said that the 73-year-old Mr. Xi looked "strong, vibrant, and fit," following recent rumors about Mr. Xi's health. But the flattery masked tensions over thorny topics including the trade war between the world's top two economies sparked by Mr. Trump's tariffs.

In a small sign of progress, U.S. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent on Wednesday announced a two-month extension of a trade truce that was due to expire in November.

## Nine killed after tourist bus catches fire in Noida

**Lavpreet Kaur**  
NEW DELHI

Nine people were killed after a tourist bus travelling from Delhi to Mahoba in Uttar Pradesh caught fire near the 33-km milestone of the Yamuna Expressway in Jewar on Wednesday night.

The bus, with around 35 passengers on board, was about 5 km from the Noida International Airport when the fire broke out, triggering panic and traffic congestion in the area.

The FIR, registered at the Jewar police station following a complaint by a survivor, said the passengers noticed a burning smell from the driver's cabin around 11.30 p.m. and repeatedly asked the crew to stop. But the driver dismissed it as a common occurrence and did not stop

to inspect the vehicle.

The FIR alleged the driver and conductor smoked in the cabin before a fire broke out near the driver's seat. When passengers raised the alarm again, the two refused to stop, telling them, "If you want to die, then die. We won't stop the bus."

By the time the bus stopped, the fire had engulfed the bus. Police have detained the drivers, Pavan Kumar and Yogesh Dixit, and the conductor, Rohit. Police have registered a case and slapped charges of culpable homicide.

Preliminary investigation suggests that a spark or blast in the air-conditioning system may have ignited the engine oil, causing the fire to spread rapidly, police said. Jewar Station House Officer Ajay Kumar Singh said six bo-



**Charred remains:** A view of the sleeper bus that caught fire along the Yamuna Expressway in Greater Noida on Thursday. ANI

dies were handed over to their families after post-mortem examination. The post-mortem of three unidentified bodies will be done on Friday. Police said the nine victims died from burns and asphyxiation.

One passenger, Rekha Bhardwaj, sustained injuries after jumping out of the bus and is currently stable.

Rinki Rajput, who was

asleep, said she woke after someone banged on the bus door.

"I did not pick up any of my belongings. I did not even put on my shoes. I just grabbed my phone and stepped out," she said.

Ms. Rajput said visibility inside the bus was poor, and passengers pushed and shoved as they tried to escape. She said someone pulled her out, while sever-

al passengers behind her were unable to escape.

**Pending challans**

*The Hindu* has found that the bus, a sleeper coach registered in Bihar and operated by Raj Kalpana Travels, had 17 pending challans amounting to ₹1.59 lakh. It had accumulated 55 challans in Delhi and Uttar Pradesh between April 2023 and August 2026, as per records on the Parivahan platform.

The violations included driving without a licence, breaches of permit conditions, failure to carry requisite documents, over-speeding, carrying goods on the roof and violations of safety norms.

The Prime Minister announced financial assistance of ₹2 lakh each for families of the deceased and ₹50,000 for the injured.

INBRIEF



Court discharges Bhujbal in library contract bribery case

A court on Thursday discharged Maharashtra Minister Chhagan Bhujbal in an alleged bribery case linked to the award of a contract for a library at the University of Mumbai, saying criminal liability cannot be based on inference of “invisible support”. The court ruled that the prosecution had failed to demonstrate the “necessary nexus” between the Minister’s official acts and the alleged criminality. “The applicant’s position as PWD Minister (when offence was registered) explains his presence in the governmental process; it does not, by itself, establish his participation in a criminal conspiracy,” it said. PTI

Jailed gangster gets 12-hour parole to marry partner

Jailed gangster, Mainpal Dhilla, was released on 12-hour custody parole to marry his Cambodian partner, whom he had met in that country after he fled India using a fake identity before being extradited last year. Dhilla (50) was brought to a farmhouse in Jhajjar district on Thursday, where the ceremony will be held. The gangster will be marrying his Cambodian partner, Meta Chan, the police said. The gangster had met her when he fled to Cambodia while jumping parole in 2018. The couple then started living together and had children. Three of her children are accompanying her for the marriage. PTI

Akhilesh takes ‘PDA Rath’ to Raebareli, says oppressed people getting united in U.P.

Trip part of SP’s broader mobilisation outreach across State focusing on its Backward, Dalit, and minority social coalition ahead of Assembly election; party to have allies, says its president

Mayank Kumar  
LUCKNOW

Samajwadi Party (SP) president Akhilesh Yadav on Thursday boarded a specially designed ‘PDA Rath’ from Lucknow for a visit to Raebareli as part of the party’s broader mobilisation outreach across Uttar Pradesh focusing on its Backward, Dalit, and minority (Pichhda, Dalit, Alpsankhyak) social coalition ahead of the 2027 State Assembly election.

He is set to take this ‘PDA Rath’ all over the State in the run-up to the poll next year. The SP said its party chief will visit places and meet people “facing atrocities at the hands of feudal forces backed by the BJP government”.

Speaking in Raebareli, Mr. Yadav urged common people to support the SP and join the PDA movement. “The chariot is a symbol of Kurukshetra and Mahabharata in our country’s culture. Even God had once recited the Gita on a similar



Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav greeting the crowd during the party’s PDA Rath Yatra in Raebareli on Thursday. ANI

chariot. The fight against these dominant, hegemonic people is not over yet. Through the PDA movement, all our oppressed and humiliated people are becoming united,” he said.

The SP chief accused the BJP government of using the bulldozer on marginalised and innocent people. “These people who are roaming around with bulldozers, they do not use them on their own people; they occupy ponds, land, houses but no action is taken. I would like to tell my workers to work towards increasing 27,000 votes in every Assembly constituency

for the 2027 election,” he said.

On a tie-up for polls, Mr. Yadav said the SP will have an alliance and the basis for deciding seats will be winability. “Whoever can win a seat should get that seat,” he said.

‘Fake Hindus’

The SP chief said Backwards and Dalits have realised their strength. “These (the BJP) are the fake Hindus who demolished countless temples by running bulldozers on Kashi, the oldest place on earth. This time, the people of PDA have realised their strength

and numbers. This time, they are neither going to bow down nor retreat. We have just defeated them in the 2024 Lok Sabha poll. In 2027, we will work to permanently eliminate them politically. This is our fight that is thousands of years old,” he said.

Asked by local reporters about the choice of Raebareli for the start of the PDA Rath Yatra, Mr. Yadav said it was in honour of SP MLA Rahul Lodhi and other party workers who were subjected to “injustice and mistreatment” in Raebareli following a clash on September 17 involving Samajwadi Chhatra Sabha and Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad members.

The Congress was guarded in its comments about the SP chief starting from Rahul Gandhi’s Lok Sabha constituency. “If they’re traveling from there, you should understand what that means. When Rahulji’s hand is in their hand, where’s the worry about anything?” said Congress MP Imran Masood.

CIC for publishing paper-wise UPSC marks of candidates

Press Trust of India  
NEW DELHI

The Central Information Commission (CIC) has recommended reinstating the practice of publishing the detailed break-up of marks obtained by selected candidates in the Civil Services (Main) Examination after finding that the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) had no record of any formal decision behind discontinuing the practice from 2018.

The recommendation came amid contradictory positions of the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) and DoPT on custody of the detailed marks.

While the UPSC told the commission that after declaration of the final result it gives the detailed break-up of marks to the DoPT and the Lal Bahadur Shastri National Academy of Administration (LBSNAA), the DoPT maintained that the detailed marks are generated and maintained solely by the UPSC.

The matter arose from an RTI application seeking comparative data of marks obtained by all selected candidates in each General Studies paper, optional subject paper and the Per-

The order came amid contradictory positions of the UPSC and DoPT on custody of detailed marks

sonality Test over 10 years, up to 2023. The applicant also sought information on how different optional subjects had fared in terms of marks. The applicant contended that while paper-wise marks of recommended candidates were publicly disclosed until CSE 2017, only aggregate marks were being made available from 2018 onwards, affecting aspirants’ ability to assess performance trends in different optional subjects.

‘No file noting’

The CIC noted that despite being given a final opportunity, the DoPT failed to produce any file noting, office memorandum, policy decision or other record substantiating the discontinuation of publication of the marks from 2018 onwards.

The commission observed that the detailed marks “should be disclosed” to ensure “transparency and fairness in the selection procedure”.

JD(U) fields Neeraj Kumar for Bihar Council polls despite stiff opposition within party ranks

Press Trust of India  
PATNA

Janata Dal (United) [JD(U)] spokesman and third-term MLC Neeraj Kumar has been given the ticket for the upcoming Bihar Legislative Council polls, notwithstanding stiff opposition to his candidature from some quarters within the party.

The name of Mr. Kumar, a former State Minister, figured in the list of four candidates announced by the party for the October 23 elections.

He will seek a fourth consecutive term from the Patna Graduates constituency, which he has been representing since 2008.

However, this time, the pitch has been queered for the trusted lieutenant of former Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, also the JD(U) supremo, with party MLA Anant Kumar Singh vowing



Neeraj Kumar

to “work towards his defeat”.

Mr. Singh has been sore with Mr. Neeraj Kumar since 2015 when the former had contested from the Mokama Assembly seat as an Independent, and the latter was in the fray as a JD(U) candidate.

Besides Neeraj Kumar, the other three candidates are spokesman Abhishek Jha, Anand Pushkar and Ghanshyam Rai.

**JSP names candidates**  
Meanwhile, the Jan Suraj Party (JSP) on Thursday an-

nounced candidates for three more of the eight Bihar Legislative Council seats, completing its list of nominees. The party, which had announced candidates for the other five seats on September 20, has fielded Anuj Singh from the Patna Graduates constituency, currently represented by JD(U) MLC Neeraj Kumar.

Other candidates named on Thursday by the party are Vimohan Kumar (Tirhut Graduates) and Bhushan Jha (Tirhut Teachers).

On September 20, the party announced names of five candidates, including MLC Afaq Ahmed, who would seek to retain the Saran Teachers seat that he won in 2022 with support of Mr. Kishor, who was then carrying out a public awareness campaign that culminated in the floating of the outfit.

Assam Cabinet approves rule that makes Muslim marriage registration compulsory

Rahul Karmakar  
GUWAHATI

The Assam Cabinet headed by Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Thursday approved a rule that makes the registration of Muslim marriages compulsory.

The Assam Muslim Marriage Registration (Compulsory) Rules, 2026, operationalise the registration framework under the Assam Compulsory Registration of Muslim Marriages and Divorces Act, 2024, which replaced a piece of legislation enacted in 1935.

The colonial-era Assam Muslim Marriage and Divorce Registration Act provided for voluntary registration, although a 2010 amendment made registration compulsory.

The 2024 legislation followed the Assam government’s decision to repeal the 1935 law. It argued that the old framework was outdated and could allow registration of marriages in-



Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma chairing a Cabinet meeting at Lok Sewa Bhawan in Guwahati on Thursday. ANI

volving minors. According to the new law, the woman must be at least 18 years old and the man 21 years old at the time of marriage.

The 2024 Act also shifted the registration process from licensed Muslim registrars or qazis to government registration officials.

The framework makes marriage registration a formal State process. Under the 2024 Act, applications require proof of identity, age and residence, along with declarations by the

couple. The law also provides for public notice and a 30-day objection period before registration.

‘Protection of rights’

The stated purpose of the 2024 legislation includes compulsory registration and protection of the rights of married Muslim women and men. It also sets conditions relating to legal age, free consent, and prohibited relationships.

The Chief Minister said the new rules are expected

to bring Muslim marriage registration under a more standardised government procedure, while creating a formal documentary record of marriages across the State.

Durga Puja bonus

The Cabinet also announced a special Durga Puja bonus for beneficiaries of the Arunodoi scheme, a social welfare initiative, under which money is transferred to the bank account of a nominated female member of each eligible household.

“Arunodoi beneficiaries will receive ₹1,500 in October instead of the regular monthly assistance of ₹1,250. The enhanced payment is being provided ahead of Durga Puja as a special festive-season benefit,” the Chief Minister said. The other decisions included providing subsidised sugar and dal at ₹100 in October instead of the earlier proposed price of ₹105.

Veeramani case: two IPS officers shunted out

The Hindu Bureau  
CHENNAI

Two senior IPS officers who were at the helm of the Chennai Police Commissionerate when a complaint accusing Gem Granites owner Veeramani of indulging in predatory sexual behaviour targeting minor girls first surfaced were removed from their posts on Thursday.

Additional Chief Secretary (Home) K. Manivasan said in an order that A. Arun, ADGP, Tamil Nadu Police Academy, and N. Kannan, Commissioner of Police, Coimbatore, were being transferred with immediate effect and placed on compulsory wait.

The order did not specify reasons for their transfer.

DGP (Training) Rajeev Kumar will now hold the additional charge of the police academy.

Patient’s family alleges Rewa hospital blood bank refused donor from another caste; administration denies charge

Mehul Malpani  
BHOPAL

The family of a patient admitted to a government-run medical college hospital in Madhya Pradesh’s Rewa has alleged that the blood bank staff refused to accept blood from an acquaintance of theirs, who belonged to the Brahmin community, asking them to arrange a donor from their own caste. The patient belongs to the Vaishya community.

The alleged incident took place on Tuesday at the government-run Sanjay Gandhi Memorial Hospital under the Shyam Shah Medical College in Rewa.

The hospital administration has, however, denied the charges, saying that



The hospital administration claimed two potential donors were rejected due to their medical conditions. FILE PHOTO

two potential donors brought by the family had been rejected due to their medical conditions.

Bajinath Vaishya, uncle of the girl patient, said that he had called a friend of his, Jitendra Pandey, to donate the blood after the doctors refused to take blood from a family mem-

ber who is under 17 years of age. The patient hails from Sidhi district.

“When we took him to the blood bank, the doctor there asked him where he had come from and said that ‘you are a Pandey and she [the patient] is a Vaishya, it won’t work’. He asked us to bring a relative

or someone from our own caste or get a written permission from our doctor,” Mr. Vaishya said.

He further alleged that the doctor treating his niece had earlier said that they could give blood of any group to the blood bank and get the matching blood for the patient.

“But when we went to him again, he asked us to arrange matching blood. Now, they are also not letting us through the gate,” he told reporters outside the hospital on Tuesday.

‘Critical condition’

Virendra Singh Vaishya, another relative, said that the girl was brought to the hospital in critical condition and needed an urgent blood transfusion.

“They are refusing to

take his [Mr. Pandey’s] blood. I have to undergo an operation in some time so I am not allowed. Where should we now go and find more people?” he said.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, hospital superintendent Dr. Priyank Sharma rejected the allegations and said that an inquiry has been conducted into the matter.

Dr. Lokesh Tripathi, blood bank in-charge at the medical college, who conducted the inquiry, said that caste is never brought up at a blood bank.

“This is a very serious matter which has come to my attention. The blood bank is the only place where caste or religion is never asked. This allegation is completely false,” he said.

Press Trust of India  
SRINAGAR

A local court in Jammu and Kashmir’s Shopian district on Thursday ordered the reopening of Darul Uloom Jamia Siraj-ul-Uloom, an educational institution declared an unlawful entity under the anti-terror law Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) earlier this year by the administration.

The court of Principal and Session Judge Shopian, Mehmood Ahmad Chowdhary, directed that until the matter is fully adjudicated, the institute be permitted to reopen and resume educational activities.

Speaking to reporters, Advocate S.M. Iqbal, who represents the institute, said that while the interim

The judge observed that govt.’s material at this prima facie stage is not sufficient to justify keeping the institution closed

relief has been granted, the main case is still ongoing.

“The main trial is still underway, but we filed an interim application because the future and education of children were at stake. Around 1,200 students were studying at Siraj-ul-Uloom, out of whom approximately 400 were residential boarders as this is a boarding and lodging institution,” Mr. Iqbal said.

He said the institute submitted that properties were deteriorating and the government had not made

proper administrative arrangements.

Until witnesses are examined and the trial concludes that unlawful activity was going on at Siraj-ul-Uloom, the institute should not remain locked, he said. “It will take time to prove that everything complies fully with the Constitution of India and no unlawful acts were committed,” Mr. Iqbal noted.

‘Excessive power used’

The advocate said that the judge observed that the government’s material at this prima facie stage is not sufficient to justify keeping the entire institution completely shut. “The court found that excessive power had been exercised relative to the allegations made,” he added.

INBRIEF



Police issue formal orders for SIT in CMRL payoffs case

The police in Keralam have issued formal orders appointing a Special Investigation Team (SIT) led by Crime Branch Superintendent of Police (SP) P. Vikraman to inquire into corruption allegations against Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan, his daughter T. Veena, former Minister P.A. Mohamed Riyas and his associates in the CMRL-Exalogic pay-off case. It will be supervised by the Additional Director General of Police (ADGP), Crime Branch.

HC upholds land acquisition to protect DRDO project area

A Division Bench of the Karnataka High Court has upheld the acquisition of 1.27 acres of additional land in Bengaluru for the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO), bringing to an end a decades-old legal dispute surrounding its Centre for Artificial Intelligence and Robotics (CAIR). The acquisition was set aside by a single judge in 2014 on the ground that landowners were not properly heard.

Karnataka HC issues notice as plea seeks MLA's prosecution

The Karnataka High Court on Thursday ordered a notice to the Election Commission of India and MLA for Srirangapatna A.B. Ramesha Bandisidde Gowda, on a petition which has questioned a special court rejecting criminal prosecution of the MLA for allegedly not disclosing certain immovable properties in his affidavit for the 2023 Assembly election. Justice Anant Ramanath Hegde passed the order on the petition filed by M.D. Adish Sagar, a voter in Mysuru.

T.N. claims Cauvery shortfall, Karnataka points to 'drought'

Tamil Nadu says it is suffering from a deficit of 20,000 tmc ft of river water while Karnataka says it did its best to comply with water disbursement responsibilities; T.N. claims kharif crop affected

Krishnadas Rajagopal  
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Thursday sought Karnataka's response to a plea by Tamil Nadu that it is suffering from a shortfall of 20 thousand million cubic feet of Cauvery river water.

Karnataka, in turn, submitted in the top court that it was facing a "terrible drought situation" and has complied, to the best, its responsibilities towards Tamil Nadu as an upper riparian State.

Appearing before a Bench headed by Justice Vikram Nath, both State governments concurred on the point that the Cauvery water was a "very sensitive" issue for them.



Both State governments concurred that Cauvery water was a 'very sensitive' issue. FILE PHOTO

sitive" issue for them.

"Karnataka is usurping all the water, depriving us of our own," senior advocate C.S. Vaidyanathan submitted for Tamil Nadu.

Senior advocate Shyam Divan, for Karnataka, said entire districts in the State have been declared as

drought-prone. "Yet, we have taken it on the chin and done our best to comply," he submitted.

The court gave Karnataka a week to file its response while scheduling the next hearing on October 12. Mr. Vaidyanathan, accompanied by senior ad-

vocate G. Umaphathy, complained that both the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee (CWRC) and the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA) have not addressed the deficit of Cauvery water due to Tamil Nadu from Karnataka.

"They are directing the release of only low quantities. Karnataka has a sizeable quantity," Mr. Vaidyanathan submitted. He said Tamil Nadu's kharif crop had been affected.

Justice Sandeep Mehta, on the Bench, said the rights of both States to be heard before the CWMA has not been denied. The parties could voice their grievances before the authorities.



If there can be housewives, there can be house husbands also, the Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court said. FILE PHOTO

The expression homemaker is gender-neutral: HC

The Hindu Bureau  
MADURAI

"If there can be housewives, there can be house husbands also. Let this become a new normal. We are of the view that this would help preserve the institution of marriage and family. The expression 'homemaker' is gender-neutral," the Madurai Bench of the Madras High Court has said.

A Division Bench of Justices G.R. Swaminathan and M.D. Sumathi said, "Unlike modern western societies, in Bharatiya culture, it is the family and not the individual that is the foundational unit."

Traditionally, the responsibility of raising financial resources rested on the husband, the wife took care of the domestic front. Both roles are entitled to equal respect. This position has been changing over the last half a century. Women are also increasingly becoming career oriented, the court said.

"We note that this is tak-

ing a toll on many relationships, particularly in the IT sector. Marriage is not proving to be a win-win proposition for career women. Since such women see marriage as an impediment to their career prospects, they choose to skip it altogether. The number of unmarried women is on the rise. The situation can probably be remedied if husbands would opt to be homemakers," the judges said.

"Until a while ago, women would happily introduce themselves as housewives. These days, they put on an embarrassed look and say, 'just a housewife', even though there is nothing to be embarrassed about," the court said.

The Bench was hearing civil miscellaneous appeals filed by a doctor couple. It said the relationship between the parties had broken down beyond repair. "The marriage that was solemnised between the parties is dissolved by a decree of divorce by mutual consent," the court said.

SC rejects MLA's plea over disqualification

The Hindu Bureau  
HYDERABAD

The Supreme Court on Thursday declined to grant any relief to Danam Nagender, whom the Telangana High Court recently disqualified as Member of Legislative Assembly under the anti-defection law.

A Bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant, Justice Joymalya Bagchi and Justice V. Mohana, said the High Court's order did not re-

quire any interference.

Senior counsel Mukul Rohatgi, appearing for Mr. Nagender, contended that there was a provision in the Tenth Schedule to condone the action of a member for giving up the party membership. The court noted that provision was applicable only when a member voted against the party whip. It cannot be applied when a legislator gives up membership of a party, the Bench noted.

21-year-old's 'suicide' revealed as murder

The Hindu Bureau  
HYDERABAD

What initially appeared to be 'death by suicide' of a 21-year-old engineering student in Telangana turned out to be a murder after the Peddapalli police found that she had allegedly been forced to consume pesticide and that a note was part of an attempt to make her death appear self-inflicted.

The police arrested Na-

veen Kumar, a lecturer at the Singareni Collieries Polytechnic, on charges of murdering Thandra Akshitarani and attempting to stage her death. Ravi Kumar, a Singareni overman accused of threatening, blackmailing, and intimidating her in the name of love, was also arrested. Both were taken into custody on September 20.

(For those in distress, counselling is available at Tele MANAS 14416.)

'There will be no shortage of prasadam at Sabarimala'

The Hindu Bureau  
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Travancore Devaswom Board (TDB) has said that there will be no shortage of *aravana prasadam* during the Thulam month puja at Sabarimala and that adequate buffer stocks will be maintained ahead of the annual Mandalam-Makara-vilakku pilgrimage season.

Addressing a press meet on Thursday, TDB president K. Jayakumar said the expansion of the *aravana* production plant was in its final stages and ruled out shortages in the future. The expansion would increase the plant's daily production capacity from 2.6 lakh tins to 3.6 lakh tins.

Dismissing reports that the Sabarimala gold crown had gone missing, Mr. Jayakumar said the 55-sovereign crown, donated by a devotee in 2012, was safely stored in the Sannidhanam strong room. The Thiruvabharanam Commissioner had personally verified its presence, he said. He also clarified that the confusion arose after a similar item was moved to the strong room at Aranmula.

Mr. Jayakumar said the board had invited tenders three times to procure jagery for *aravana* production as part of efforts to ensure transparency in raw material procurement. A sample supplied by a Pune-based company had passed inspection, and the Devaswom Vigilance Superintendent of Police (SP) would visit the company to assess its capabilities.

A 'tender-cum-e-auction' system would also be introduced for allocating shops at Sabarimala to curb irregularities in the auction process.

Practice makes perfect



High on confidence: Members of the rescue team of The Singareni Collieries Company Limited (SCCL) participating in the 55th two-day Zonal Mines Rescue Competition in Peddapalli district in Telangana on Thursday. NAGARA GOPAL

DYFI targets Keralam CM over chartered flight to Malappuram

G. Anand  
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

A 'freebie' row centred on Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan's recent travel to flood-hit Malappuram district on a chartered flight lent by an "anonymous benefactor" appeared to dominate the political narrative in Keralam on Thursday.

The Democratic Youth Federation of India (DYFI) is organising painting competitions across the State, urging the public to use their "imagination" to conjure up the likeness of the "mysterious sponsor" whose identity Mr. Satheesan had refused to reveal. In a cynical jibe at the

power cuts affecting the State, the DYFI has offered an emergency lamp as the top prize, along with candles as consolation prize.

Mr. Satheesan on Wednesday said his travel to Malappuram "did not burden the public exchequer."

CPI(M) leader T.M. Thomas Isaac told *The Hindu* that the DYFI's protest was merely the Opposition's "warning shot" to the UDF government. He said the LDF would follow up the DYFI's political action by seeking legal recourse to spotlight "the conflict of interest, opaqueness, and erosion of ethics" at the centre of the current scandal.

Red sanders smuggler wanted in 99 cases held by A.P. police

A.D. Rangarajan  
KADAPA

The Kadapa police in Andhra Pradesh reportedly nabbed Simpathi Jakeer alias Shaik Chempati Jakeer, a notorious red sanders smuggler with 99 cases against him, including 82 cases related to red sanders smuggling.

Jakeer is reportedly known to have attacked the police as many as 80 times in the past, including attempting to stab officials with a knife, running them over with his vehicle or hurling large stones while trying to escape.

Following intelligence inputs, the police intensified surveillance on the various smuggling routes ov-



SP Nachiket Vishwanath Shelke says red sanders smuggling will be treated as organised crime.

er the past two days. One of the teams reportedly intercepted a carriage truck and a four-wheeler early on Thursday. Jakeer was surprisingly found with the group. Upon noticing him, Chapadu Sub Inspector (SI) Chinna Peddaiah warned him to surrender,

while a constable tried to apprehend him. Jakeer reportedly tried to attack the police personnel with a knife, but the Sub Inspector fired two rounds in the air and another at Jakeer's left leg, injuring him.

Superintendent of Police (SP) Nachiket Vishwanath Shelke said red sanders smuggling would be dealt with as an organised crime, and the financial transactions of the accused would also be investigated.

Mr. Nachiket observed that the red sanders, native to the Seshachalam forest, would be treated as national treasure. "Although there is widespread demand, nobody is allowed to fell the trees or transport the wood," he added.

VB-G RAM G: Karnataka creates 1.56 crore person-days of work

The Hindu Bureau  
BENGALURU

Karnataka has generated 1.56 crore person-days of employment under the Viksit Bharat - Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-G RAM G) scheme, as the State faces a severe drought situation, Rural Development and Panchayat Raj (RDPR) Minister Eshwar Khandre told the Legislative Assembly on Thursday.

In a response during a special discussion on drought, BJP member V. Sunil Kumar raised concerns over the implementation of the employment scheme and said that preparations should have been made to utilise it on a larg-

**Scheme should have been utilised on a larger scale in drought-affected areas, says BJP MLA**

er scale in drought-affected areas.

Mr. Khandre said that several works were being undertaken under the scheme, including the construction of farm ponds and check dams, dredging and rejuvenation of lakes, and measures aimed at improving groundwater levels. He said 318 works had been taken up under the scheme.

According to the Minister, the government has allocated ₹2,900 crore for the current quarter for the

VB-G RAM G scheme, while ₹1,000 crore has already been released to districts as an advance. Mr. Khandre said the Union and the State governments were contributing ₹1,700 crore and ₹1,200 crore each towards the programme. He also said the State government was taking steps to ensure that people did not migrate in search of employment and was providing work locally.

The Minister further said there had been complaints regarding the release of funds under the scheme and that the government was taking steps to address them.

Mr. Kumar alleged that the State had given greater priority to the real estate sector than farmers.

Vigilance raids detect corruption in sports councils in Keralam

The Hindu Bureau  
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau (VACB) has detected widespread financial irregularities, suspected corruption and administrative lapses in the Kerala State Sports Council and district sports councils during a Statewide surprise inspection.

The inspection unearthed irregularities including the diversion of funds and procurement without following tender procedures. It also detected the selection of ineligible athletes for State championships and receipt of payments from contrac-

tors through digital payment platforms.

Among the major findings were the diversion of ₹1.30 crore from security deposits collected by the Kozhikode District Sports Council, irregularities in purchases worth over ₹14 lakh in Alappuzha, missing sports equipment and laptops at the State Sports Council headquarters, and instances of officials receiving payments from athletes and contractors through UPI transactions.

The inspection was undertaken as part of an initiative by the VACB to detect and prevent corruption in government institutions.

# SC reserves orders on plea over OBC creamy layer policy

# SC directs EC to set timeline to resolve Trinamool dispute

## It is for Parliament to enact law against legislators who resign and re-contest bypolls, says Madras HC

# *INS Trishul* in France for the 24th edition of Varuna

# Experts call for safer roads 7 years after MV Act amendment

# ED raids in money laundering case kicks up a political storm in Punjab

# Minor girl molested in Bihar's Samastipur, four arrested in case

CM  
YK

# CJP seeks resignation of CEC, warns of nationwide agitation

Gyanesh Kumar must resign in 48 hours to ensure free and fair elections, says Abhijeet Dipke; CJP also demands criminal proceedings against CEC, restoration of pre-SIR rolls of January 2025 and repeal of Act on appointment of poll body chief

**Suruchi Kumari**  
NEW DELHI

The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) on Thursday demanded the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar for “undermining” voter rights through the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

The group warned of a nation-wide agitation and “Jantar Mantar 2.0” if Mr. Kumar did not step down within 48 hours.

The CJP’s demand for Mr. Kumar’s resignation comes a day after an investigation by *The Indian Express* revealed that the other two Election Commissioners, Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, objected on record at least 14 times between October 2025 and August 2026 to decisions related to SIR, many of which, they said, were taken without their knowledge.



**Seeking action:** CJP leaders Saurav Das, Abhijeet Dipke and Ashutosh Ranka speaking to the media. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

“To ensure free and fair elections, Mr. Kumar must resign,” CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke told a press conference. He alleged that the electoral process had been ‘rigged’ and that the right to vote was being taken away from citizens, for which the CEC was responsible.

Mr. Dipke said that Opposition parties should take a stand against election rigging. “If you know the election is rigged, you

should take a stand; you cannot both participate in the election and speak against rigging,” he said.

CJP co-convenor Saurav Das said, “Everywhere we are going as part of our *School Theek Karo* campaign, people are upset and asking for a change. One of the important tools for change is our right to vote. It cannot be compromised.”

Besides the call for the resignation, the CJP also

made two other demands, including criminal proceedings against the CEC.

CJP co-convenor Ashutosh Ranka said, “An independent inquiry commission should be constituted to look into all proceedings of SIR so far. The Supreme Court should seize all files related to decision-making in SIR before they are destroyed by EC.” He demanded that all the upcoming elections be halted and pre-SIR rolls of January 2025 restored in all States.

The CJP sought the repeal of the Appointment of Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners Act 2023. “The new law should be redrawn with active participation of civil society, an independent selection process that inspires public confidence,” he said.

“We need to hit the streets. Who is Mr. Kumar to revoke our voting rights and strike our names off?” he added.

Mr. Dipke called the CEC a threat to India’s democracy, citing that the ruling party had won in more States than it did during the peak of ‘Modi wave’. “He should resign immediately because he is the biggest threat to India’s democracy. What did democracy mean in our country? Democracy meant that people elected the government. Since Gyanesh Kumar became the Chief Election Commissioner, the government has been deciding who will be allowed to vote and who will not. Is this democracy?” he asked.

Mr. Das, referring to the report, said, “The other two Election Commissioners clearly called this illegal, but even then, the Election Commission, under the direction of Mr. Kumar and whoever is directing or controlling him has continued carrying out these illegal actions for months.”

# Opposition to move fresh notice in Parliament for Gyanesh Kumar’s removal

**Sobhana K. Nair**  
NEW DELHI

The Opposition parties will move a fresh notice in both Houses of Parliament seeking the removal of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, even as a previous petition moved in the Rajya Sabha on April 24 is pending with Upper House Chairman C.P. Radhakrishnan.

The Opposition is also gearing up for joint action on the issue and could soon call for a meeting under the banner of the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) bloc. A senior Opposition leader said that a dialogue is going on among like-minded parties to discuss the modalities.

In view of the Cockroach Janta Party’s 48-hour ultimatum calling for Mr. Kumar’s resignation, the INDIA bloc is anxious not to be seen as latecomers on the issue. “The Opposition will certainly be moving, especially in light of the



Gyanesh Kumar

new revelations. Our earlier motion submitted on April 24, in the RS had nine specific charges. That motion is still pending. There will be more specific charges,” Congress leader Jairam Ramesh said.

## ‘Must act swiftly’

The Trinamool Congress, which played a key role in the drafting of two previous petitions for Mr. Kumar’s removal, said a new petition should be moved at the earliest. “The Trinamool is very happy to play the role of a squirrel in the garden. The Opposition has to act unitedly and

swiftly,” party leader Derek O’Brien said.

It was on March 12 that the Opposition first moved a notice seeking Mr. Kumar’s removal. This notice was signed by 63 Rajya Sabha MPs and 130 Lok Sabha MPs. It contained seven charges against the CEC, including that his appointment itself was “tainted, with the law governing his selection, facing a challenge in the Supreme Court. The Opposition also claimed that Mr. Kumar’s previous postings reflected “deep executive embeddedness”. This notice was dismissed on April 7.

On April 24, the Opposition again moved a notice in the Rajya Sabha, signed by 73 Opposition members, this time with nine charges. The 13-page notice moved in April made several allegations including disenfranchisement” in West Bengal and Uttar Pradesh, the “illegal abuse” of power and “asymmetrical enforcement of the Model Code of Conduct”.

## SC advocate seeks to file contempt plea against CEC

**Krishnadas Rajagopal**  
NEW DELHI

Supreme Court advocate Brajesh Singh on Thursday sought statutory consent of the Attorney-General of India to initiate criminal contempt action against Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar following a media report revealing a “complete breakdown of multi-member consensus within the Election Commission (EC)”.

Referring to a report alleging “deep structural subversions”, he said that the other Election Commissioners, Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi, formally registered written objections at least 14 times over the last 10 months.

He submitted that the alleged actions by Mr. Kumar violated court precedents, which mandate that the EC must function through institutional consensus.

Mr. Singh said the CEC was only *primus inter pares* or first among equals. He did not possess absolute authority.

# EC’s expanded logical discrepancy list for third phase of SIR keeps voters on their toes

**Sreeparna Chakrabarty**  
NEW DELHI

Rajiv Chopra (name changed), a resident of Vaishali Colony in Pitampura in North West Delhi, was making last-minute preparations for a trip abroad when a neighbour called to inform him that his children were on the Election Commission’s logical discrepancy list that was being circulated in his society.

During a quick call to the Booth Level Officer (BLO), he learnt that his children had been flagged despite being in the draft list as the age gap between them was not more than nine months. Well, it cannot be since his 30-year-old children are twins.

The mandatory nine-month age gap between siblings is one of the many categories of logical discrepancies that electors have to navigate to get into the voter lists during the third Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise. Up to 11 distinct categories of logical discrepancies have been



**Put to hardship:** In Delhi, 19.33 lakh electors have received such discrepancy notices. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

identified and applied across various States and Union Territories (such as Karnataka, Haryana, Delhi, Telangana and others), expanding from the original four categories initially used when the concept was introduced during West Bengal’s SIR exercise.

## Many categories

Among the categories are an age gap of less than 15 years between a voter and their parent; age gap of less than 40 years between a voter and their grandparent; more than six siblings linked with a single parent;

discrepancies or spelling variations in a parent’s name between the current electoral roll and the previous revision; changes in relative mapping between revisions (e.g., father in previous rolls vs. mother in current rolls); marital mapping mismatch (e.g., female voter linked to her father in the previous roll but mapped to her husband in the current roll without cross-referencing); and age progression discrepancy (implausible age leaps or mathematical discrepancies between different revision cycles).

The discrepancies are flagged under a centralised AI system through the ERONet, or the Electoral Roll Officers’ Network. The software attempts “progeny-mapping” – linking a voter to their parents’ entries on the base roll and the resultant inconsistencies are flagged.

## Introduced in Bengal

The logical discrepancy category first surfaced during the SIR in West Bengal when approximately 1.36 crore voters received notices. In Delhi, where SIR is being done currently, 19.33 lakh electors have received discrepancy notices while 20.35 lakh have received the notices in Karnataka.

The problem in this is that “logical discrepancies” has never been clearly defined in any official communication – neither in the EC’s notice in May 2026 nor in the original SIR order from June 2025. Thus, the actual parameters or methodology used to assign someone to this category were not publicly documented. Another pro-

blem is with the ERONet software itself, which two Election Commissioners have flagged for having become increasingly centralised. They have said that Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) have complained that they are unable to access the platform from their end in many cases.

Former Trinamool Congress MP and Right to Information Act activist Saket Gokhale said the EC was “hiding” details of the software, claiming it was a “trade secret”. In a post on X, he shared RTI applications in which he had asked the EC about details of the software. “Shocking-ly, the EC refused to disclose the details claiming it would affect ‘commercial confidence’”, he said.

“The software consists of an opaque algorithm which has been used to delete voters through a centralised system in Delhi [bypassing EROs]. A software used by a public authority is being kept secret for commercial interests,” he said.

# Left parties to hold week-long protest against SIR and CEC

**The Hindu Bureau**  
NEW DELHI

Five Left parties issued a joint statement demanding the ouster of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar and a halt to the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

The parties announced a week-long protest across the country from September 26 to October 2 on the issue.

The parties signed the statement after an impromptu meeting between Communist Party of India (Marxist) general secretary M.A. Baby, CPI general secretary D. Raja, and Communist Party of India (Marxist-Leninist) Liberation general secretary Dipankar Bhattacharya at the CPI (M)’s headquarters. The other signatories are the Revolutionary Socialist Party, and the All India Forward Bloc.

The Left parties have also demanded that the SIR be halted and that voting rights be restored to all the

**They have demanded that the SIR be halted and that voting rights be restored to all people**

people who have been wrongfully excluded from the electoral rolls.

The parties also demanded that the EC’s “independent and democratic functioning” be reinstated, and that the present system of appointment of Election Commissioners be replaced with a mechanism based on the Supreme Court’s proposed selection committee comprising the Prime Minister, the Leader of the Opposition, and the Chief Justice of India.

The statement said the report confirms concerns repeatedly raised by Opposition parties and exposed the hollowness of claims that the SIR and electoral roll management process are transparent and decentralised.

# Rahul Gandhi’s allegations on vote theft lack credible evidence, says BJP

**The Hindu Bureau**  
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Thursday hit back at the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, calling him a “master of deception” with “zero political knowledge”, while responding to his allegations about “vote theft” and other election-related issues.

At a press conference, BJP MP and spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi said the Congress leader’s accusations lacked credible evidence.

Countering Mr. Gandhi’s charge that every leader and party faced anti-incumbency except Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah, Mr. Trivedi said: “It is correct that anti-incumbency definitely is very consistent and strong



**In reality, anti-incumbency for the Congress and Gandhi family has become so strong that they cannot win their own seat without help of their ally**  
**SUDHANSHU TRIVEDI**  
BJP leader

against the Congress. The Congress has not returned to power in Tamil Nadu since 1967 and since 1977 in West Bengal, where there was a Communist government for 34 years... then Mamata Banerjee formed three governments.”

“After Rahul ji and Sonia ji came, the Congress is facing more anti-incumbency,” he said, citing the examples of Madhya Pradesh and Kerala.

He alleged that the Congress had now been struggling to return to power as

elections had become more transparent, with the process monitored through CCTV cameras, central paramilitary forces deployed instead of local police, and an independent media and judiciary.

“In reality, today anti-incumbency for the Congress and the Gandhi family has become so strong that they cannot win their own seat without the help of their ally,” he said, alleging that Mr. Gandhi and Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi Vadra won Kera-

lam’s Wayanad seat with the Muslim League’s support, and Amethi and Rae Bareilly seats in Uttar Pradesh with the help of the Samajwadi Party.

## Questions report

Questioning the basis of a news report about communications between the Chief Election Commissioner and the two Election Commissioners, Mr. Trivedi asked whether there was any evidence that any decision in the Election Commission of India had not been taken unanimously.

He said the special intensive revision process is authorised under the Representation of the People Act, arguing that voter lists needed proper verification to determine voter eligibility, particularly in areas impacted by “demographic change”.

# BJP spent more than half of ₹529.38 cr. funds for recent polls in West Bengal

**The Hindu Bureau**  
NEW DELHI

The BJP spent ₹286.99 crore on West Bengal Assembly elections, which is more than half of the total of ₹529.38 crore that the party spent on the recent Assembly polls in four states and one Union Territory, according to expenditure statements filed with the Election Commission.

The Congress spent ₹248.55 crore for all these elections held in April-May.

In Bengal where it came to power for the first time, ousting the Trinamool Congress, the BJP spent ₹217.16 crore on general campaigning and ₹69.83 crore on candidates. It won 207 of 293 seats for which results were declared. West Bengal has 294 Assembly seats, and the EC ordered a repoll in Falta constituency follow-



The expenditure statement of the Trinamool Congress, which is the BJP’s principal rival in Bengal, has not been made public yet. AP

ing allegations of severe electoral offences there.

The Congress spent ₹42.08 crore in Bengal through its central headquarters and the State unit. This included an expenditure of ₹12.96 crore on general campaigning and ₹29.12 crore on candidates and related expenses. The party won merely two of the 293 seats contested.

The CPI(M), which ruled Bengal for decades before losing power in 2011, spent ₹8.23 crore, including expenditure on candidates. It contested 197 seats and won only one. The expenditure statement of the Trinamool Congress, which is the BJP’s principal rival in Bengal, has not been made public yet.

In Keralam, the Con-

gress spent ₹105.34 crore, more than the BJP’s ₹82.67 crore. Of the Congress’ total outlay, ₹71.30 crore went towards general campaigning and ₹34.05 crore towards candidates and related expenses.

The BJP reported spending ₹82.67 crore – ₹54.93 crore on general campaigning and ₹27.74 crore on candidates. In comparison, the CPI(M), which is a major force in Keralam, reported an expenditure of ₹28.60 crore.

The Congress-led alliance won 102 seats – 63 by the Congress alone, throwing the CPI(M)-led Left Democratic Front out of power. The CPI(M) won 26 and the BJP three. The State Assembly has 140 seats. The BJP reported spending ₹96.27 crore in Assam, ₹51.56 crore in Tamil Nadu and ₹11.90 crore in Puducherry.



HEALTH

When cancer treatment is no longer working

Modern oncology has transformed countless lives. Yet an important gap remains. We do not prepare patients and their families for uncertainty. What happens if the treatment stops helping? How much should the patient know? When should children be told? How do we decide what matters most now?

V. Divya Sai

The hardest conversation in cancer care rarely begins with the words, “There is nothing more we can do.” It usually begins much earlier. “Should we tell him?” “Can we try one more treatment?” “Will she lose hope if she knows?”

These questions are asked quietly: in hospital corridors, outside intensive care units, or after doctors have left the room. They are spoken in whispers because families are not simply making medical decisions; they are trying to protect someone they love.

As a palliative medicine physician working alongside oncology teams, I have learned that when treatment is no longer working as expected, families often find themselves facing conversations they never imagined having. The challenge is not only accepting that the disease has changed; it is learning how to talk about what comes next.

**Conversations we prepare least for**

Modern oncology has transformed countless lives. New drugs, targeted therapies, immunotherapy and better supportive care have helped many people live longer than ever before. Yet an important gap remains.

We prepare families remarkably well for chemotherapy schedules, blood tests and scan reports. We prepare them far less for conversations about uncertainty. What happens if the treatment stops helping? How much should the patient know? When should children be told? How do we decide what matters most now?

These questions do not signal that hope has disappeared. They signal that hope is changing.

A young man I recently cared for had advanced blood cancer and was admitted to the ICU with severe pain. Over the next few days, his greatest distress was not only physical. Watching critically ill patients around him, he became convinced that he would be next. When he finally asked, “Am I going to die?” he was not asking for a statistical answer. He was asking whether someone would help him understand what was happening.

Another family kept asking whether there was “one last option.” As our conversation unfolded, it became clear that they were not asking for another medicine. They wanted enough time to gather siblings from different cities, celebrate one more birthday together, and prepare for conversations they had



**Care that continues:** Patients frequently sense when their condition is changing, even when nobody says it directly. Silence can sometimes create greater fear than truth because people begin imagining conversations they are not allowed to have. GETTY IMAGES

been postponing. Often, the real question is different from the one being asked aloud.

**Weaving honesty and hope**

Many families worry that honest conversations will extinguish hope. In reality, compassionate communication does not require choosing between honesty and kindness. Patients frequently sense when their condition is changing, even when nobody says it directly. Silence can sometimes create greater fear than truth because people begin imagining conversations they are not allowed to have.

Good communication means understanding how much information a patient wishes to receive, respecting cultural and family dynamics, and revisiting discussions as situations evolve. It is rarely a single conversation. More often, it is a series of conversations built on trust. Hope also evolves. Early in illness, hope may mean cure. Later, it may mean attending a daughter's wedding, spending time at home instead of the hospital, sleeping through the night without pain, or simply being able to share one meaningful conversation with a loved one.

One of the biggest misconceptions is

**Good communication means understanding how much information a patient wishes to receive, respecting cultural and family dynamics, and revisiting discussions as situations evolve**

that palliative care begins only after treatment ends.

In reality, it works alongside cancer treatment by helping patients manage pain, breathlessness, nausea, anxiety, fatigue and caregiver distress while supporting difficult decision-making. Some of the most meaningful palliative care conversations happen while patients are still receiving active treatment. Instead of asking only, “What is the next treatment?”, we also ask: “What matters most to you?”; “What are you hoping for?” and “What are you worried about?”

These questions often reveal priorities that laboratory values never can.

Here are some conversations families should not delay having with loved ones who have cancer. When facing advanced cancer, especially, these discussions are easier before a crisis occurs: Ask what the patient wants to know about their illness. Discuss goals that matter to them beyond

treatment. Talk about symptom control early rather than waiting for unbearable pain. Identify who should make decisions if the patient cannot. Ask for a palliative care consultation early-alongside oncology-not only during the final days.

These conversations are not about giving up. They are about giving families the chance to make decisions with clarity instead of panic.

There is one moment I return to often. A family once told me, after losing someone they loved, “We don't remember every medicine that was given. We remember that she wasn't in pain, that we were able to sit together, and that we got to say goodbye.”

Years later, families rarely remember every chemotherapy cycle. They remember whether someone explained what was happening; whether suffering was relieved; whether they felt alone. Perhaps that is the real purpose of these conversations. Not to predict the future; not to remove grief: but to ensure that even when treatment changes, care never does.

(Dr. V. Divya Sai is a palliative medicine specialist at MNJ Institute of Oncology & Regional Cancer Centre, Hyderabad. vdivyasai22@gmail.com)

THE GIST

Modern oncology has transformed countless lives. New drugs, targeted therapies, immunotherapy and better supportive care have helped many people live longer than ever before. Yet an important gap remains

Many families worry that honest conversations will extinguish hope. In reality, compassionate communication does not require choosing between honesty and kindness

These conversations are not about giving up. They are about giving families the chance to make decisions with clarity instead of panic

BIG SHOT



**Ground zero:** A child being vaccinated at a health camp setup by a mobile boat clinic in the Barballa river island in Nalbari district of Assam. Several people in Assam live on “chars”, or temporary river islands and sandbars where access to even basic healthcare can be a challenge. AFP

GERD is more than just heartburn: why it is important to understand the difference

Athira Elssa Johnson

Heartburn is commonly described as acidity and treated with antacids.

But gastro-oesophageal reflux disease (GERD) is not simply acidity. It occurs when the stomach contents repeatedly move into the oesophagus because the normal anti-reflux barrier does not function effectively.

“GERD is not simply a problem of producing too much acid,” said Vishnu Abishek Raju, senior consultant, medical gastroenterology, Apollo Hospitals, Chennai. Heartburn, therefore, is a symptom, rather than a diagnosis. Some people living with reflux have visible inflammation of the oesophagus, while others have symptoms without any visible injury. GERD is common in India. A 2021 analysis of nine Indian studies involving 20,614 people estimated its pooled prevalence at 15.6%.

How reflux occurs

The lower oesophageal sphincter acts as a valve between the oesophagus and stomach. It can undergo brief, inappropriate relaxations, allowing stomach contents to move upwards.

A hiatal hernia can weaken the anti-reflux barrier by allowing part of the stomach to move above the diaphragm. Obesity, particularly excess abdominal fat,



A burning sensation may reflect acid reflux, heightened oesophageal sensitivity or another disorder, and persistent symptoms need to be assessed. GETTY IMAGES

increases pressure within the abdomen, while delayed gastric emptying can increase the volume and pressure inside the stomach.

The oesophagus also has protective mechanisms. Saliva helps clear refluxed material, while alkaline mucus helps limit acid-related injury.

“People may have acid reflux within a stipulated period. But if that goes beyond the protective mechanisms of the body, those defensive mechanisms fail and the food pipe can get damaged, a condition called oesophagitis,” said Arul Prakash, clinical lead and senior consultant in medical gastroenterology, SRM Prime Hospital, Chennai.

The amount of reflux does not always correspond to the severity of symptoms.

“Some people have increased

sensitivity of the oesophagus, so even normal amounts of reflux can produce significant burning or chest discomfort,” Dr. Abishek Raju said. This includes reflux hypersensitivity and functional heartburn. In reflux hypersensitivity, symptoms are linked to reflux events despite normal overall reflux exposure. In functional heartburn, symptoms occur without evidence that reflux is responsible.

“These are people who may feel a burning sensation with almost anything they eat because the nerves in the food pipe are very sensitive,” Dr. Arul Prakash said. This is one reason why simply increasing acid-suppressing medicines does not necessarily resolve persistent symptoms.

A response to a proton pump

inhibitor (PPI) can support a diagnosis of GERD, but it does not prove that reflux is the cause.

When symptoms continue despite appropriately used treatment, doctors may need to investigate other causes, including oesophageal motility disorders and disorders of oesophageal sensitivity.

Endoscopy is particularly important when there are alarm symptoms such as difficulty or pain while swallowing, bleeding, unexplained weight loss, persistent vomiting or anaemia. It can detect oesophagitis, ulcers, strictures and Barrett's oesophagus.

A normal endoscopy, however, does not exclude reflux. In such cases, 24-hour pH-impedance monitoring can measure reflux episodes, distinguish acid from non-acid reflux and assess whether symptoms occur in association with reflux.

Lifestyle measures

Weight loss can reduce reflux symptoms in people who are overweight or obese. Avoiding food for about three hours before lying down can help, particularly with night-time symptoms.

Food triggers vary. Rather than eliminating multiple foods routinely, patients should identify those that consistently worsen their symptoms.

(athira.elssa@thehindu.co.in)



## A nation’s song

### Vande Mataram’s rendition must be in the spirit of unity in diversity

Patriotism is not just reverence for a territory or a flag but is the embodiment of solidarity with fellow citizens in a nation-state. The idea of a nation as a bond transcends family, community or faith, uniting citizens through common values and a pursuit of prosperity. National symbols and anthems exist to hone that bond. When they are changed or modified to compel citizens to accept a majoritarian version, their purpose is defeated. India’s freedom fighting generation understood this. Which is why, in 1937, the Congress Working Committee resolved that only the first two stanzas of Bankim Chatterjee’s *Vande Mataram* should be sung at national gatherings, since the later stanzas invoke the motherland as Hindu deities. When *Jana Gana Mana* was adopted as the National Anthem on January 24, 1950, India’s first President Rajendra Prasad said that *Vande Mataram*, even though there is no mention of a “national song” in the Constitution, would be “honoured equally”. Since then, the two-stanza version has allowed citizens of all faiths to partake in a song that stirred the freedom struggle and popularised by artists such as Lata Mangeshkar and A.R. Rahman.

In the last year or so, the BJP-led Union government has sought to unsettle this inclusive compact. Since the song’s 150th anniversary in 2025, it has pushed for all six stanzas to be recited. The Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) issued directions and circulars in 2026 and Parliament passed the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Act, 2026 with little debate – actions that are in line with the BJP’s habit of imposing uniformity and majoritarian preference on all citizens. The amendment extends Section 3 of the 1971 Act, which punishes anyone who intentionally prevents the singing of the National Anthem or disturbs an assembly engaged in such singing, to the National Song. *Per se* it does not compel anyone to sing or define the National Song or its stanzas. But read alongside the MHA orders, which prescribe an official version of all six stanzas, mandate mass singing at public functions, and place the song before the anthem, it amounts to compulsion, as a petition by T.M. Krishna in the Supreme Court has argued. The Court has rightly observed that the state may decide what the National Song is, but cannot penalise conscientious objectors in line with *Bijoe Emmanuel* (1986). This judgment held that no law obliges anyone to sing the Anthem, standing in respectful silence is no offence and executive instructions without statutory backing cannot curtail fundamental rights. The Court must apply *Bijoe Emmanuel* in full, set aside the MHA’s orders and make it clear that silence cannot be read as “disturbance”. By reverting to the vision of the freedom generation, the Court will do justice to the idea of unity in diversity.

## A chance to retreat

### The Greenland agreement allows Donald Trump to scale down his threats

President Donald Trump first raised the possibility of acquiring Greenland, a Danish territory, during his first term in office. After his return to the White House in January 2025, he doubled down on his threat, saying that he would make the island American territory one way or the other. This incensed Denmark, a founding member of NATO, as well as America’s other allies in Europe. Denmark reassessed its sovereignty over the island but, as a compromise, promised to let the U.S. expand its military presence. On September 22, the leaders of the U.S., Denmark and Greenland signed a new security deal, which, according to Mr. Trump, would allow the U.S. to do “what is necessary in Greenland”. For Mr. Trump, who had even raised the possibility of using force to take over the territory, the deal is a retreat from his acquisition demand. But at the same time, it re-endorses the U.S. role as the primary security provider – it already stations some 150 troops in Greenland at its Pituffik Space Base. Under the agreement, Washington would build military facilities in Narsarsuaq in the south, where the U.S. had an airfield during the Second World War, and in Mestersvlg in the east, along the Norwegian Sea.

The 1951 U.S.-Denmark security agreement provides Washington the broad rights to build military bases in the ice-covered island. During the Second World War and the Cold War, the U.S. had more than 30 bases and installations on the island. Most were shut down over the years, particularly after the Cold War. In recent years, Trump administration officials raised concerns about the growing activities of China and Russia in the Arctic, including alleged espionage. As the Arctic region’s strategic profile is rising – partly because melting ice opens up previously impassable regions – the U.S. wants to consolidate its position and believes that Greenland would play a key role in that strategy. The agreement says that even if Greenland, which has a population of around 50,000, becomes independent, it would respect the deal with the U.S. and stay in NATO. In other words, this provides the U.S. indefinite access to the island’s military facilities. The deal also stipulates that no hostile power (non-NATO countries) can establish military facilities in Greenland or invest in its sensitive areas (mainly rare earths). Denmark has already blocked Chinese investments in the territory and the deal effectively formalises that restriction. So, on paper, Greenland could remain a self-governing, autonomous territory within the Kingdom of Denmark, while the U.S. would be its strategic patron with greater control – a diplomatic arrangement acceptable to Washington, NATO and Denmark.

One of the enduring ironies of the Indian political system is that political parties, which are considered the principal stakeholders of electoral democracy, do not find a mention in the Constitution, except in the Tenth Schedule. They exist as “associations” in furtherance of the fundamental rights under Article 19. No effort has been made to define and straitjacket their legal character to conform to being a company, trust, society, firm or a not-for-profit company. Even so, they continue to enjoy the benefit of income-tax exemption in an unprecedented and unparalleled manner, sometimes becoming mysterious receptacles of inexplicable monies. Just as there are shell companies that fulfil unstated purposes, there are shell political parties that serve an insidious intent. And thereby hangs a tale.

### The mystery of political funding

That tale was partially unravelled by a recent BBC investigation that revealed extraordinary donations received by six Registered Unrecognised Political Parties (RUPPs). A well-known yet intriguing aspect of Indian politics – ugly and ubiquitous – stands exposed. Political parties and their benefactors thrive in this system, even if it appears reprehensible, unlawful and disturbing.

Earlier, the Association for Democratic Reforms (ADR) released a report on July 18, 2025, which found a 223% rise in the declared income of RUPPs in FY2022-23. It noted that, of the 2,764 RUPPs, only 739 had submitted their financial records for the year to the Election Commission of India (ECI), the sole custodian, under the law, of the fate and fortunes of political parties.

In a press note, “Cleaning up the Electoral System” (August 9, 2025), the ECI said it had ‘delisted’ 334 RUPPs out of 2,854 “as part of a comprehensive and continuous strategy...to clean up the electoral system.” It would be interesting to see whether the six parties in question are part of the ECI’s “continuous strategy”.

On October 16, 1994, T.N. Seshan, then Chief Election Commissioner of India, issued an order under the Election Symbols (Reservation and Allotment) Order, 1968, in which he highlighted the “adhocism” and the “sorry state of affairs prevailing in almost all political parties in the country, whether recognised National or State parties or registered-unrecognised parties”. He observed, “I have yet to come across any party whose affairs are being run in accordance with the provisions of its constitution or rules and regulations.” Through the order, T.N. Seshan put all political parties on “notice” to set their house in order, declaring that the ECI would not remain a “mute spectator”. In subsequent guidelines prescribing the format for registration under Section 29A of the Representation of the People Act (RPA), 1951, the ECI stated in paragraph 3(xxiii) that a party seeking registration must declare in its constitution that it will contest elections within five years of registration and that, if it does not “contest elections continuously



Ashok Lavasa

Former Election Commissioner of India and a former Union Finance Secretary

The Election Commission of India should scrutinise political parties and political finance rather than legitimate voters

for six years”, it shall “be automatically taken off the list of recognised parties”.

‘Taking off’ or ‘delisting’ does not mean deregistration, as the ECI is not generally empowered to deregister political parties. Similarly, even if RUPPs are ‘unrecognised’, they remain eligible to receive contributions under Section 29B of the RPA, while their tax treatment is governed by Section 13A of the Income-tax Act. “Recognition” is governed by Order 6 of the Election Symbols Order, which distinguishes between ‘recognized’ and ‘unrecognized’ political parties for the purpose of allotting symbols and lays down the criteria for their classification. T.N. Seshan amended the Symbols Order and introduced Order 16A, which empowers the ECI to “suspend or withdraw recognition of a recognised political party for its failure to observe MCC [Model Code of Conduct] or follow lawful directions and instructions of the Commission”. That provision sits, rather harmlessly, in the statute book, empowering an ECI that has generally been reluctant to strike.

Hence, whether ‘delisted’ or ‘unrecognized’, the parties remain eligible to receive contributions. It is a matter for investigation whether such donations continued to qualify for tax exemptions, given that the intent behind the delisting was to disqualify them.

### The scale of ‘political wealth’

A paper published by Venkatesh Nayak, a senior researcher at the Commonwealth Human Rights Initiative (which was also reported by a leading media site), revealed that 22 political parties collectively had ₹18,742.31 crore at their disposal for the 2024 general election. This included funds in their kitty when the election was announced and ₹7,416.31 crore in donations raised between the announcement and the completion of the election. After the election, these parties had ₹14,848.46 crore remaining in their custody, including cash in hand, money held in bank accounts and fixed deposits, after incurring ₹3,861.57 crore in election-related expenditure during the campaign period, according to the accounts submitted to the ECI.

The study found that, over the last decade, the exchequer ‘lost’ ₹11,813 crore in taxes due to exemptions for political donations, with individual donors and Hindu Undivided Families overtaking corporates in donating to political parties. In FY2022-23, individual donors claimed exemptions worth ₹2,275.85 crore, dwarfing corporate claims of ₹514.4 crore and those of firms and associations, at ₹115.71 crore. Declared donations to political parties increased from ₹714 crore (43 parties) in 2015-16 to ₹7,203 crore (27 parties) in 2023-24. Yet, only 41.76% of total donations, amounting to ₹28,287 crore over nine years, were claimed as tax-exempt, raising questions about the remaining 58%. Mr. Nayak asks: “What incentives are driving them to donate without tax relief? The lack of transparency obscures answers.”

What added the thickest layer of secrecy was

the so-called reform of electoral bonds introduced by the ruling party in 2018, which made the entire business of political finance murky. Although the scheme was declared unconstitutional by the Supreme Court of India in 2024, the details of the donations subsequently disclosed raised questions that remain unanswered. Most RUPPs were not eligible to receive electoral bonds, as they were restricted to parties that had “secured at least 1% of the votes in the latest Lok Sabha or State Legislative Assembly elections”. Who, then, made these contributions, and why?

### The top court and ECI must act

Political parties have shown scant interest in transparency. They united in resisting the 2013 order of the Central Information Commission (CIC) bringing them under the Right to Information Act. Interestingly, besides the CIC, neither the ECI nor the Supreme Court has shown any inclination to enforce it. The Income-Tax Department and the Enforcement Directorate might not consider it a priority to scrutinise the accounts of political parties as they do those of ordinary taxpayers. The ECI lacks the mandate, intent or wherewithal to question the accounts mechanically submitted by political parties. Submission of the accounts is enough to comply with the letter of the law, even if its spirit gasps. How will that spirit be revived, and who will revive it?

It is incumbent upon the Court to order a court-monitored probe into the saga of electoral bonds and the alleged *quid pro quo* in the petitions pending before it. The probe should also examine the phenomenon of ‘insignificant’ RUPPs receiving and spending huge contributions without participating in the electoral process in any substantial manner. Surely, such “shell” parties cannot justify spending crores as “administrative expenses”.

Exercising its powers under Article 324 – described by the Court in the landmark judgment of *Kanhiya Lal Omar vs R.K. Trivedi and Others* as a “reservoir of authority” for the ECI – the ECI should order political parties to have their accounts audited by the Comptroller and Auditor General of India or its nominee. It should also consider imposing a limit on expenditure by political parties during elections, a measure it has recommended repeatedly. Tax exemptions on donations should be limited to the prescribed expenditure limit. All other donations that enrich the parties should be fully taxed.

The ECI should establish an automatic procedure to ‘deregister’ any RUPP that does not contest elections in accordance with its guidelines and develop a centralised digital portal where all registered parties can upload their financial data in standardised formats.

Let the ECI spend its energy and authority on ‘purifying’ the electoral environment rather than on chasing genuine electors off the electoral rolls. Until then, ‘We the People’ must continue to scream *‘Hami yaha chhau* (we are here”).

# Policing the line between publicity and justice

Within minutes of an arrest anywhere in India today, a face – handcuffed, flanked by policemen, sometimes garlanded with placards cataloguing the crime – starts circulating on social media, often before the accused is produced before a magistrate. A Supreme Court of India PIL seeking a nationwide media protocol/police media briefings has forced a question that Indian policing has quietly avoided: under what law do we do this, should we do it, and where should it stop?

Photographs of wanted persons and reward notices have solved crimes, helped recover missing children, and brought fugitives to book years after trails went cold – the public, alerted, has done what a thinly stretched police force alone could not.

The justification is strong; the legal architecture is weak. What is needed is a clear legal basis, not a habit inherited from mere precedent.

### Current law and practice

No single statute permits or prohibits police from publishing photographs of accused persons. What exists is a patchwork of colonial-era regulations, an identification statute and the general architecture of criminal procedure.

Section 84 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023 (Section 82 of the Code of Criminal Procedure or CrPC) allows courts to proclaim absconders and publish proclamations in newspapers. It says nothing about photographs, but attaching one has become settled practice because it serves the purpose of securing the person’s appearance. This judicial process is triggered only after a warrant fails; it does not, however, provide a basis for publicity at the investigation stage.

Publication at the investigation stage rests instead on the general powers of an investigating



Rupin Sharma

IPS officer who is the Director General of Police, Nagaland

Before releasing the photograph of a person accused, arrested, but not yet tried, police must ask whether the investigation requires it

officer (Io): every person must assist the police in preventing and investigating offences, and an Io may examine anyone with relevant information. Publishing photographs on social media to solicit identification, trace absconders or find witnesses is a digital-age extension of the old “Hue and Cry Notice”, in State Police Manuals – provisions that predate Independence and whose language (“description of the subject”) is broad enough to plausibly cover photographs and rewards.

Reward announcements stand on firmer, narrower ground, typically governed by State Police Regulations under the Police Act, 1861, which vest sanctioning authority in a hierarchy ranging from the Station House Officer (SHO) to the State government. No prior warrant or proclamation is required; it is an exercise of administrative discretion, not a judicial precondition. The Criminal Procedure (Identification) Act, 2022, governs the taking, storage and use of measurements – including photographs – for identification, but is often wrongly cited as enabling their publication. It says nothing, however, about circulating them.

### Constitutional limits

Article 21, jurisprudence has sharpened, not softened. Presumption of innocence remains central to criminal justice, and courts increasingly recognise that broadcasting an arrested person’s face as a fait accompli of guilt, before any charge is framed can cause real, irreversible harm. The Rajasthan High Court termed such practices “institutional humiliation” digital circulation is permanent, searchable and indifferent to later acquittal.

The Bureau of Police Research and Development prepared a draft manual on media briefings by police personnel and shared it with the Ministry of Home Affairs in July 2024. In January 2026, the Supreme Court said the *amicus*

had prepared a Police Manual for Media Briefing and directed the States to evolve appropriate policies based on it within three months. Some categories are already absolute red lines: a juvenile in conflict with the law cannot be identified except in the child’s best interest and with the Juvenile Justice Board’s permission; a sexual assault survivor’s identity is protected by law. The intriguing debate concerns the ordinary adult – accused, arrested, but not yet tried.

### The distinction that matters

Publication sits on a scale: at one end, legitimate investigative necessity – crime prevention, public order and law-and-order purposes; at the other, the showcasing of police achievements. . Photographs released merely to showcase arrests serve police optics at the accused’s expense and can prejudice public opinion before trial.

American law treats “wanted” notices as public-record exceptions to privacy law, but agencies are trained to frame them carefully – “alleged,” “wanted for questioning” – to preserve the presumption of innocence even while seeking help. British policing, more conservatively, withholds arrested persons’ identities altogether.

What is needed is not an outright ban on soliciting public assistance – that would be legally unwarranted and self-defeating – but a codified, uniform national protocol that distinguishes proportionate, need-based disclosure from prejudicial publicity; mandates blackout categories such as juveniles and sexual-offence complainants; requires time-bound review and takedown once the investigative purpose is served or an accused is discharged or acquitted; and applies uniformly across States.

One question before any photograph goes out could be a beginning: is the disclosure necessary to the investigation, or merely convenient to the narrative?

## LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

### State of the ECI

The Special Intensive Revision (SIR), one feels, is turning out to be a failed exercise in the country. Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar appears to have failed the Constitution and the people of the nation in the conduct of the

SIR. He should resign (Page 1, “Opposition calls for CEC’s exit over ‘illegal conduct’”, September 24). That said, why did Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi remain silent for so long over their differences with the CEC on SIR deletions and related

issues, when the electoral damage has already been caused? There is something more to it than meets the eye. This is a constitutional crisis in the country. **S. Ramakrishnasayee**, Chennai

It is really astonishing to see the way things have been

unfolding at the Election Commission of India over the last few months. While everyone expects an autonomous constitutional body to function democratically, it appears to have become a one-man show under the leadership of Gyanesh Kumar. He has centralised

decision-making, lending credibility to the serious allegations made by the Opposition parties. **Kolikonda Sarathbabu**, Khammam, Telangana

It is extremely worrying to find the CEC in the eye of a storm. A position that shapes the destiny and fate

of the nation in the midst of a serious controversy does not augur well for the nation. Corrective action needs to be taken on a war footing.

**Balasubramaniam Pavani**, Secunderabad

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# Should permanent membership, veto powers of the UNSC be abolished?



**Amitabh Mattoo**  
Dean of School of International Studies, JNU



**Swaran Singh**  
Former Professor of the School of International Studies, JNU

## PARLEY

In the ongoing session of the UN General Assembly (UNGA), France has made a proposal to enhance the functioning of the UN, especially in dealing with collective security and the use of veto. France has been advocating that the use of veto in the UN Security Council (UNSC) be “regulated” when it comes to dealing with humanitarian crises such as in Sudan, Lebanon or in cases of genocide. France believes that the use of veto is not a matter of “privilege” but of “responsibility”. So, should permanent membership and veto powers of the UN Security Council be abolished? Amitabh Mattoo and Swaran Singh discuss the question in a conversation moderated by Kallol Bhattacharjee. Edited excerpts:

**Is it realistically possible to imagine an UNSC where veto would be “regulated” as the French proposal suggested?**

**Amitabh Mattoo:** What Emmanuel Macron (President of France) articulated in the UNGA on September 22 is not entirely new. What we are seeing is really a renewed push behind what used to be called the French-Mexican initiative, first launched in 2015, under which permanent members of the SC would voluntarily refrain from using the veto in situations involving genocide, crimes against humanity, and large-scale war crimes. It’s not an attempt to abolish the veto or amend the UN charter. It’s essentially an exercise in self-restraint by the P5 (permanent members of the UNSC: U.S., U.K., France, China and Russia). What gives the initiative fresh significance is not just Mr. Macron’s speech, but the political momentum behind it. France and Mexico both announced this week that 128 states now support the declaration, with 21 joining in the last four months. And the significant part is that the U.K., another P5 country, has now joined France in accepting the principle.

So for the first time, two of the five permanent members have committed themselves to this form of voluntary restraint.

But I think we should also distinguish between three different questions which are often conflated – the use of the veto, accountability for the use of the veto, and the much larger question of reform of the Security Council. Mr. Macron’s initiative addresses only the first. It says in effect, even if the veto remains, surely there must be circumstances of exceptional human suffering in which a permanent member agrees not to exercise it. It is, as I said, a modest incremental proposition institutionally, but potentially significant



A general view of the UNGA in New York City, U.S., on September 22. REUTERS

normatively in terms of what we want the world to be like. It seeks to change the political behaviour of the five permanent countries without undertaking what seems to be the almost impossible task of rewriting the charter. So, it’s a modest proposal and it has got some momentum, but whether it translates into reality, we’ll have to wait and see.

**Does the current situation in UNGA indicate that the P5 is now divided between the France-U.K. and Russia-U.S.-China factions on the use of veto?**

**Swaran Singh:** Clearly, the U.K. and France are not the heavyweights among the P5. Therefore, I think it is easier for France and the U.K. to make that principled position saying that the P5, which wield veto power, should be able to better regulate or manage how fundamentally the power is utilised; to make sure that the UNSC is able to take action and that it does not get paralysed. In fact, the contradiction of 2013 itself was driven by the fact that in the civil war in Syria, Chinese and Russian vetoes were making it impossible for the UNSC to pass any resolution condemning Syria. After the August 2013 chemical weapons attack in Ghouta in September, the then French President Francois Hollande had in his speech proposed a ‘code of good conduct’ for the UNSC. This is where, for the first time, a kind of proposition was made that the P5 could voluntarily restrain the use of veto in cases of genocide, crimes against humanity or larger war crimes. I think the attempt was to skirt amending the UN Charter and still make it much more contemporaneous. None of the P5 are talking of eliminating veto power that they have. There are multiple versions among the five as to how they wish to reform the UN Security Council.

As an ideal, we believe that we live in a world



As an ideal, we believe that we live in a world of sovereign equality, but in reality, because of the way power is distributed, it is impossible for any international organisation to survive – not just become effective – but even survive if they happen to take a decision against any of the major powers

SWARAN SINGH

of sovereign equality, but in reality, because of the way power is distributed, it is impossible for any international organisation to survive – not just become effective – but even survive if they happen to take a decision against any of the major powers. Incidentally, veto is not a word mentioned in the UN Charter and it was created through a separate mechanism. But the premise is that any international organisation must not take a decision against the fundamental interests of any major power if they wish to survive.

**While doubts persist about the veto, the question is will veto continue to be extended to new members of the UNSC whenever they are inducted?**

**AM:** Apart from Mr. Macron’s or the France-Mexican initiative, there have been incremental reforms which fall short of trying to amend the UN Charter. There was an earlier Liechtenstein initiative, which was adopted by the UNGA in 2022, which took a different route. It did not prevent a permanent member from exercising the veto. Instead, whenever a veto was cast, the General Assembly would be convened within 10 working days to debate the issue. In other words, a veto will no longer be allowed to simply terminate the conversation. The permanent member concerned would have to explain and defend its action on the floor of the UNGA. That was one initiative which was passed by the UNGA. A third initiative, also similar to the French-Mexican initiative, is the ‘ACT code of conduct’ or the Accountability, Coherence and Transparency Initiative. This goes beyond the P5 and asks members of the Security Council, including the non-permanent members, not to vote against credible action designed to prevent or halt genocide, crimes against humanity and war crimes.

Again, its strength is moral and political rather than legally coercive. So I would resist the debate as being simply ‘retain or abolish the veto’. We now have several overlapping approaches – abolition, extension of the veto to new permanent members in the name of equality, voluntary restraint in case of

mass atrocities, political accountability after a veto is exercised, and the final question of broader structural reform of the Security Council itself. So my own analytical conclusion would be that Mr. Macron’s proposal matters precisely because it is pragmatic; reformist rather than revolutionary. Formal abolition of the veto would ultimately require charter amendment and the consent of the very permanent members whose privilege is being removed.

**Can you please explain the issue of accountability in the debate on veto?**

**AM:** Short of an amendment of the UN Security Council; an amendment of the veto provisions; or the larger restructuring of the UN Security Council, I think there is great merit in the ‘Liechtenstein initiative’, whereby the debate would continue within the UNGA. It would not prevent or terminate the conversation from happening in the floor of the UNGA, where the permanent member which has exercised the veto would have to clearly demonstrate to the members of the UN what the reasons were behind the exercise of the veto, especially when it has vetoed an action designed to prevent or halt genocide or crimes against humanity.

Calling upon the permanent member to explain and defend its actions would not necessarily prevent anything when there is real national self-interest at stake, but at least it will make the permanent members, one of the P5 countries which has exercised the veto, become a little more cautious in the use of its power because it would know that it would need to justify and become accountable for its action.

**Is the French proposal transparent or honest about the framing of certain conflicts that are going on such as the Israeli campaign in the Gaza Strip?**

**SS:** I think words such as honesty and justice are most misused in international relations. There is no doubt that all the UN members, whether they are in the Security Council or in the General Assembly, come to the world’s largest platform with their own interpretations, with their own understanding of each of these conflicts that you just listed. So in that sense, there is this important difficulty of word versus the spirit of various international law regimes or the Charter of the United Nations.



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## NOTEBOOK

## How rare archival photos revealed the magic of Madras

‘Madras on Stage’, the fourth edition of The Hindu’s ‘Made of Chennai’ archives exhibition showcased the rich cultural heritage of the city

K. Arunkumar

“Madras on Stage,” the fourth edition of *The Hindu*’s ‘Made of Chennai’ photo archives exhibition – held at Kasturi Buildings, the newspaper’s corporate head office – concluded on September 15. This year’s exhibition attracted a larger crowd than previous years, and notables from various walks of life visited it.

We at the Library Department, which serves as the archives of *The Hindu*, started collecting photographs for the exhibition in the second week of July. The curator, Thirupurasundari Sevel, suggested a division of 33% performing arts (national and international), 33% drama/stage, and 33% cinema. We chose to display pictures from the 1920s all the way to the 2010s to ensure that we did not miss out on any cultural activities or performing arts. We have in our repository nearly 2.5 to 3 million pictures across varied subjects, which include digital copies, black-and-white and colour prints, negatives, and colour transparencies. Of these physical prints, negatives, and transparencies, 60% were readily available in digital format; for the rest, we had to search through physical copies.

The curator gave us helpful clues and ideas. She also shared a timeline of key programmes and cultural events in Madras over the years. Using these leads, we cross-checked news items published in *The Hindu* and *Sport & Pastime* (a magazine published by The Hindu Group from 1947 to 1968), confirmed the dates, and searched our archives for pictures.

Finding some photos was tough, such as the 1927 photograph of Pammal Sambanda Mudaliar with the cast of his play by the Suguna Vilasa Sabha. Tracking down cinema stills of M.K. Thyagaraja Bhagavathar (MKT) shot in Madras was similarly exhausting. We hold only very few photographs from MKT’s films; the 1934 musical *Pavalakkodi*, directed by K. Subrahmanyam, provided the sole Madras-based still in our collection.

On the brighter side, we came across photographs of many international performers who appeared in Madras from the 1950s to the 1990s, including Boney M, American jazz musicians, Egyptian folk dancers, Tibetan Amdo drama troupes, Russian Ramayana casts, and Russian ballet dancers. We collected a total of 600 pictures and shortlisted 181. Out of these, 100 pictures were physically exhibited, while all 181 were displayed on a television screen at the venue.

Right from the inauguration on August 14, school and college students visited the exhibition almost daily. Film and drama personalities, politicians, journalists, and public officials were among the other notable visitors. The exhibition was inaugurated by Tamil Nadu Minister for School Education, Tamil Development and Information A. Rajmohan. Tamil Nadu Minister for Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments S. Ramesh also toured the display.

Historian and heritage activist V. Sriram appreciated the exhibits and helped identify several figures in the photographs – updates we have since incorporated into our archival captions.

Actor Pasupathy, whose photo from his Koothu-p-Pattarai days was on display, visited with his family and spotted a familiar face in the frame – retired Justice Prabha Sridevan, his co-star in *The Conduct of Life*, a play by Maria Irene Fornes. Actress and activist Revathi also dropped by, thrilled to spot three photographs capturing her participation in various social causes.

Other notable visitors included drama veterans Kathadi S. Ramamurthy, S.Ve. Shekher, and Madhu Balaji; theatre and television artist S. Varadarajan; cartoonist Madhan; singer Chinmayi; actor-journalist Chitra Lakshmanan; filmmaker Halitha Shameem; screenplay-dialogue writer Anand Kumaresan; and cinema PROs Diamond Babu and Nikhil Murukan.

We’re already looking forward to celebrating Madras again next year.

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## PICTURE OF THE WEEK

### Panorama of colour



Lightning strikes seen over the city skyline in Mumbai, Maharashtra on September 21. Several regions in the State have been facing a prolonged dry spell, causing extensive crop loss. The situation is so dire that the Maharashtra Cooperation Minister Babasaheb Patil said the government will soon declare 100% drought in the State. EMMANUAL YOGINI

## FROM THE ARCHIVES

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 25, 1976

### No winner at Ford-Carter first round

Washington, September 24: The first face-to-face encounter between President Ford and his Democratic challenger, Mr. Jimmy Carter, last night lived up to the expectations of those who had organised this nationally televised 90-minute political spectacular – an opportunity for the American people to learn first hand from the two Presidential candidates, with their divergent economic philosophies, what they

## The Hindu

proposed to do about such things like unemployment, inflation and taxes.

The confrontation over fiscal policies produced some sharp exchanges, though some of the dry statistics that were bandied about may have gone over the heads of ordinary viewers.

The debate was staged at Philadelphia’s Walnut theatre. The first of three bouts of the political prize-fight of the decade – the last such debate took place in 1960 when Kennedy and Nixon were contesting the Presidency – was marked by well-controlled exchanges by the Presidential rivals. Evidently, the two men had not only spent hours cramming facts and figures but also rehearsing to be seen as natural as possible before their audience.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 25, 1926

### Advertising the empire

An “Englishman” cable from London dated September 22 states: Emphasising that the opening of the Imperial Conference is expected to synchronise with the launching of the Empire Marketing Board’s £1,000,000 scheme for “advertising the empire”, “The Daily News” political correspondent suggests that this effort to focus the serious attention of British subjects to the Dominions might be strengthened partially by opening the Conference to the press. The paper says there is reason to believe that the British Government is not opposed to this.

# Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Share of UPI transaction value risks MDR charges

**10** in per cent. Only about 10% of the overall value of UPI transactions could face the risk of charges being passed on to consumers under the merchant discount rate (MDR), with large corporates absorbing most of the proposed costs, NPCI chief Dilip Asbe said on Thursday. PTI

New hires by PhonePe to expand merchant network in rural India

**20,000** PhonePe said on Thursday it plans to hire 20,000 additional on-roll sales employees over the next year as part of a push to expand its merchant network into India's smaller towns and villages. PTI

Amount to be spent by U.S. Energy Dept. amid skyrocketing demand

**2** in \$ billion. The Energy Department is set to announce it will spend almost \$2 billion to try to squeeze more electricity out of the nation's stressed power grid, as President Donald Trump's administration steps up efforts to avoid blackouts amid skyrocketing energy demand spurred by AI. AP

Projects stuck due to court cases, regulatory decisions by J&K govt.

**113** As many as 113 development projects worth ₹245 crore in J&K are held up due to court cases and pending decisions, the government said on Thursday. It said the projects were under status quo owing to decisions pending before courts or competent authorities. PTI

Percentage rise in India's tech funding in January-September

**7** in per cent. Funding in the Indian technology ecosystem rose 7% year-on-year to \$10.3 billion during the first nine months of 2026, driven by larger deal sizes even as overall deal volumes contracted sharply, said a report by data intelligence platform Tracxn. PTI  
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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## The unbearable burden of freedom

Surinder Koli spent close to 20 years in prison before his convictions in the Nithari cases unravelled and the court acquitted him in 2025; his case shows the structural failure to support wrongfully convicted people after acquittal, including through psychosocial support, housing, employment and monetary assistance

LETTER & SPIRIT

Maitreyi Misra  
Anup Surendranath

**S**urinder Koli was acquitted and released from prison in November 2025 by the Supreme Court after spending close to 20 years in prison, many of which were on death row. On September 18, he was found dead. Although an autopsy is awaited, early news reports described it as a suicide.

Accused of the infamous Nithari cases, at the time of his arrest in 2006 and over the next many years, Koli not only bore the brunt of the criminal justice system but also of wild public allegations. Referred to as ‘the butcher of Nithari’ and publicly accused of cannibalism, the media dredged up an image of Koli that became a frequent source of material fuelling the ‘true crime’ genre. Based on snippets from his ‘confessions’ (later found to be given under torture), the public discourse against Koli was so totalising as to leave no space for uncertainty.

The cases unravelled

Between 2009 and 2022, Koli was found guilty and sentenced to death by the trial court in 13 cases. One by one, the cases against him unravelled, as court after court found that there was no real evidence against him. In several cases, the Allahabad High Court characterised the investigation as botched up and an “easy course of implicating a poor servant of the house by demonising him, without taking due care of probing more serious aspects.” When acquitting him in 2025 in the last case, the Supreme Court made it clear that the High Court’s comments could not be dismissed as a ‘rhetorical excess’ and that the evidentiary basis for Koli’s conviction was unreliable, inadmissible and in violation of his rights. Yet, Koli came close to being executed in



Surinder Koli. FILE PHOTO

2014. A stay on execution, issued by the Supreme Court just four hours before, averted that fate.

We mention these facts not to relitigate his case, but to remind ourselves of the mourning we owe Koli. He was publicly demonised, and so a public mourning. We remind ourselves of these facts because they also raise a question. What does a justice system owe to a person it has wrongly taken so much from?

For a person like Koli, whose name still conjured a particular and monstrous image, rebuilding his life posed additional challenges. According to news reports, Koli had adopted a different name to secure housing and employment. This may have been because of the stigma associated with his name and his fear of the public’s reaction. Even after being acquitted, he was condemned by the same society he had to re-enter. The seriously botched investigation, however, has little bearing on public memory.

A structural failure

Koli’s case is not a one-off. India has a serious wrongful convictions problem. An analysis by The Square Circle Clinic of 25 years of data on death sentences shows

that 40% of death sentences imposed by trial courts ultimately result in acquittals by appellate courts. That is a staggering number, made worse by the fact that individuals are made to live under a death sentence even when their convictions are barely sustainable. Once set at liberty, neither the State nor society provides them with adequate support to return and reintegrate, even as we may have subjected them to the full force of our vengeance.

There have been a few instances where the Supreme Court has explicitly recognised such travesties. It has awarded compensation in a few cases and, in 2025, recognised the need for a legislative response to wrongful convictions. But this barely skims the surface of a deep structural problem. As institutions, our prisons are far from being effective in preparing individuals for reintegration into society. Asking a prison to be interested in a category of prisoners the justice system has declared to be executed is being naive about the political and structural reality of our prisons.

These failures, which begin inside prisons, are only compounded outside. Prisoners, particularly those like Koli,

who are released after spending decades incarcerated, have to readjust to a world vastly different from the one they entered when they went to prison. This readjustment involves unlearning, relearning, and learning new things that a person, now much older and unaccustomed to such a stimulating environment, has to undergo. Life has to begin anew with livelihood and housing to be found, and relationships to be re-established. The immense cognitive, emotional, psychological, and physical reorientation required is difficult to imagine.

Beyond acquittal

The eagerness driving our collective retributive instinct appears missing when we are faced with the consequences of that bloodlust. The response to such injustice cannot be ad hoc sympathy but must be structural and underpinned by principles of integrity, accountability and remediation. The integrity of a justice system lies in a meaningful acknowledgement of wrongdoing when the wrong occurs. Psychosocial support to cope with the realities of their new world healthily; safe halfway homes which allow the person to slowly adjust to a constantly changing world; reconnection with the family that they left behind; and monetary support and employment schemes to allow them a chance at independent livelihood must be seen as an inalienable part of a harsh criminal justice system, and at minimum when it exercises its coercive powers wrongfully.

Over the course of 13 acquittals, Koli lost close to 20 years of his life to a justice system that never once acknowledged the harm it caused him. It is unlikely that the injustice to Koli will become the moral reckoning it ought to be. Absent any introspection, we condemn ourselves to see many Kolis.

(The authors are with The Square Circle Clinic, NALSAR University of Law. Views expressed are personal)

THE GIST

▼ The criminal justice system’s handling of Koli’s case raises questions about accountability when investigations and convictions cause grave harm

▼ Wrongfully convicted people released after prolonged incarceration face immense challenges in readjusting to society and rebuilding their lives

▼ The State’s response to wrongful convictions must go beyond compensation or ad hoc sympathy to include meaningful acknowledgement, accountability and measures for rehabilitation and reintegration

## What are the alternatives to the SWIFT payment system?

Why are countries looking beyond SWIFT? How are CIPS, SPFS and mBridge faring?

G R Rajeev

The story so far:

**T**he New Delhi Declaration that came out of the recent BRICS Summit in the National Capital resolved to increase trade between member-countries and payments in national currencies. Days before the summit, a report by the news agency Reuters quoted sources as saying that at the event, India would push to link central bank digital currencies (CBDCs) for cross-border payments across BRICS nations, despite political and technical hurdles that could limit progress. The proposal to link CBDCs would be part of the agenda for the leaders’ meeting, the sources said, though the limited adoption of digital currencies globally could complicate implementation, the report added. The proposal was, however, not part of the Declaration.

Multiple wars and U.S. weaponisation of the dollar through financial sanctions are making countries in the Global South

think of bypassing the so-far universally accepted Belgium-based SWIFT system for inter-country payments. The attempts to do so have been patchy, but there is an increasingly felt need to have other options.

What are some of the alternatives to the SWIFT payment system?

Project mBridge is a group comprising the Bank of Thailand, the Central Bank of the United Arab Emirates, the Digital Currency Institute of the People’s Bank of China, the Hong Kong Monetary Authority, and the Saudi Central Bank.

The Cross-Border Interbank Payment System (CIPS), a Reuters report said, is backed by the People’s Bank of China. China launched the CIPS clearing and settlement services system in 2015 to internationalise yuan use. It allows global banks to clear cross-border yuan transactions directly onshore, instead of through clearing banks in offshore yuan hubs, the report said.

The System for Transfer of Financial

Messages, or SPFS, was developed by Russia in 2014 to bypass Western sanctions. In 2022, Russian banks were cut off from SWIFT, and the SPFS was of help.

SEPAMA, Iran’s local interbank telecom system, has as many as 52 branches of Iranian banks and four unnamed foreign banks connecting with 106 banks using the SPFS, the Central Bank of Iran said in 2023.

How are these systems faring?

The Bank for International Settlements (BIS), an international financial institution owned by central banks to foster international monetary and financial cooperation, exited Project mBridge on October 31, 2024, after hand-holding it since 2019, when the Hong Kong Monetary Authority and the Bank of Thailand launched the system. The mBridge, a cross-bloc multi-CBDC platform with no Western bank, attained minimum viability status in 2024. It was envisaged for direct peer-to-peer CBDC

settlement without going through correspondent banks. The project team developed a new blockchain – the mBridge Ledger – custom-built by central banks to serve as a specialised and flexible platform for implementation of multi-currency cross-border payments in CBDCs, the BIS website says.

The BIS’s exit came under a cloud, with media reports saying it was because mBridge could provide the basis for a BRICS initiative to circumvent sanctions on Russia. A May 2016 Forbes report said that by late 2025, mBridge was in practice “a renminbi-denominated wholesale settlement rail for trade between China and the Gulf, running outside the dollar correspondent system”.

The renminbi’s inclusion in the basket of currencies making up the Special Drawing Right, an international reserve asset created by the International Monetary Fund, has increased the acceptance of CIPS, said a November 2025 opinion piece in The Hindu by Biswajit Dhar, a trade economist and former professor at Jawaharlal Nehru University. The CIPS now has participants in more than 120 countries, including all BRICS members except India.

A South China Morning Post report says CIPS processed 679.8 billion yuan of transactions on average per day in 2025. “While the CIPS has gained ground, it remains far smaller in scale than established global systems, such as the U.S.-based Clearing House Interbank Payments System,” it said. Beijing now

appears to be moving towards building CIPS into a global platform compliant with multi-currency settlements and other foreign payment channels, the report quoted a study led by Ju Jiandong, a chair professor at Tsinghua University’s PBC School of Finance.

The SPFS, formed as Russian entities were banned from SWIFT, has grown at a record pace in 2023 as Moscow ramped up efforts to resolve financial shortcomings wrought by sanctions over the Ukraine war. Alla Bakina, director of the Russian central bank’s national payment system department, said 50 new entities joined Russia’s alternative system in 2023, taking the total to 440, of which more than 100 are non-residents.

How do India-Russia trade settlements happen now?

Russia and India, the second-largest importer of Russian oil, have built a functioning payments infrastructure using roubles and rupees, which now account for 96% of bilateral trade, Ivan Nosov, head of Sberbank in India, said. “I am ready to say that this is one of the best-established mechanisms for Russia’s payments with other countries,” he said.

According to official data, 22 Russian banks, including Sberbank, Russia’s largest lender, which was tasked with developing the payments infrastructure, and 17 Indian banks are currently servicing bilateral trade, a Reuters report said.

CACHE



Mark Zuckerberg is taking a different route, stating that AI companies have a powerful incentive to build systems that are trustworthy. AP

# Why Meta’s Zuckerberg rebuffed Dario Amodei’s AI slowdown calls

Zuckerberg says AI labs can develop advanced models safely without an industry-wide slowdown, while Amodei wants frontier development paced to let safety research catch up; disagreement centres on whether AI risks should be managed by individual labs or through common safety standards

John Xavier

Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg has entered the growing debate over whether the AI industry must slow down the development of advanced language models, arguing that individual labs already have strong reasons and enough tools to build AI more safely without asking for an industry-wide slowdown.

Mr. Zuckerberg’s perspective, shared on platform X, comes just days after Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei called for the AI industry to “pace the frontier,” setting up one of the clearest disagreements yet among the leaders of the companies building increasingly capable AI systems.

Mr. Amodei has warned that AI development is beginning to outstrip the labs’ ability to understand and control the systems it is creating. One of the primary reasons behind this change is that newer AI models are being built by existing AI systems. This makes it difficult for human builders to understand how these are wired internally.

He pointed specifically to the rise of recursive self-improvement and a recent incident involving an AI agent swarm that carried out cyberattacks beyond its assigned task.

As a result, Mr. Amodei wants frontier labs to slow the speed of capability gains so safety research can catch up.

Mr. Zuckerberg is taking a different route, stating that AI companies have a powerful incentive to build systems that are trustworthy. “Every lab has the responsibility and incentive to move at the pace required to train its models safely,” Mr. Zuckerberg wrote.

At the heart of the disagreement is not

whether AI safety matters. Both executives argue that it does. They differ in how the industry should respond to the risks created by increasingly capable systems. Mr. Amodei says that competition can itself become part of the problem. If every frontier lab races to develop more capable AI systems, an individual company may have difficulty slowing down on its own, even when its researchers believe additional safety work is necessary.

So he proposes common safety standards among countries, possibly including China.

But Mr. Zuckerberg points to market incentives and individual firms’ responsibilities. He notes that users will not stick with AI agents that ignore their instructions or act against their interests. This shows that companies will have to improve alignment if they need commercial success.

“Trust and alignment are quickly becoming the most important capabilities that will differentiate agents and models,” Mr. Zuckerberg wrote.

Rather than treating alignment as a constraint on AI development, Mr. Zuckerberg sees it as a differentiator. He points to Meta’s own development process as evidence that companies can choose to slow down when necessary.

Meta, apparently, delayed the release of its Muse AI model while the company worked on safety and security.

“We just did it as part of our day-to-day work because it was clearly the right thing for people and for us,” he wrote.

**Independent evaluations**  
This man was a legendary king of the Solar dynasty. In the Mahabharata, Narada says this king is the only one to find a place among the gods. This king was the subject of the first Indian motion picture and can be seen in this painting by Raja Ravi Varma. Name the king. Also name the man who made the motion picture.

supports independent evaluation and has called for the use of outside evaluators and advisers, arguing that a larger and more diverse ecosystem of evaluators would improve the quality of AI safety efforts.

Mr. Amodei, too, wants frontier AI labs to give independent third-party evaluators access to their models so they can examine not only finished ones but also ones under training.

But the duo disagree on why the evaluation needs to take place. For Mr. Amodei, this independent evaluation is part of a larger framework for deliberately pacing frontier development. But Zuckerberg wants it to be part of a system in which individual companies remain responsible for deciding when their models are safe enough to advance.

**A competitive landscape**  
Mr. Zuckerberg has highlighted that a “significant majority” of a lab’s computing resources must be used to serve users rather than allowing increasingly powerful AI systems to consume enormous resources for recursive self-improvement – a scientific method that makes AI systems help build the next generation of AI.

While Mr. Amodei has warned that recursive self-improvement could advance AI development to the point where safety efforts can no longer keep up, Mr. Zuckerberg’s says that keeping most computing resources focused on human-directed applications can help preserve human control.

The safest path ahead, according to him, need not necessarily be the one in which a small number of companies become the gatekeepers of an increasingly powerful AI system. The

market needs to have more players who can build on top of existing layer and further extend the frontier.

But as open source alternatives mushroom, including ones from Meta, frontier labs like Anthropic and OpenAI will try their best to stay in the lead. That’s a hard pill to swallow for frontier labs like Anthropic and OpenAI at a time when open source models are getting better – and that, ultimately, is the more uncomfortable reading of this dispute.

**Market dynamics**  
Markets have historically been good at sorting out which products survive. The ones that serve buyers well succeed, the ones that don’t fall away.

Producers compete on quality and trust rather than asking regulators to referee the game or telling buyers what risks they should fear. But that is quite what is happening here. Two of the very labs pushing hardest for coordinated pacing are also the ones watching their early lead narrow fastest, as open source catches up.

A call to pace the frontier, however sincerely made, also happens to slow the field bearing down on you.

A frontier, by definition, is something a community pushes outward together, not a line a few gatekeepers draw and ask everyone else to stay behind.

Settling for a smaller, cautiously managed version of AI because a small number of companies say it’s safer risks becoming its own kind of Plato’s cave, where the shadows on the wall are chosen for us.

The better path may be messier: more builders, more models, and the freedom for users to subscribe to the ones they trust most.



FROM THE ARCHIVES

## Know your English

S. Upendran

“You look beat. What have you been up to?”

“Beat? So, she’s already called you and told you about everything”.

“Who? What are you talking about?”

“I am talking about Sujatha, of course. Did she tell you that she beat me in a game of chess yesterday”

“Sujatha has better things to do than tell me about your silly games.”

“How did you know that I was beat?”

“Oh that! When you say that someone looks beat, what you are implying is that the individual is looking exhausted. It’s an expression used in informal contexts.”

“Really? I didn’t know that.”

“That’s one of the meanings of the word ‘beat’ anyway. Here’s an example. After working out in the gym for half-an-hour, I was beat.”

“You mean to say that you have started working out in the gym”

“That was just an example.”

“But you do need to go to the gym, though. You’re getting a paunch.”

“I am not!”

“Let’s not get into an argument. How about this example? After jogging three miles, I was beat.”

“We were dead beat after the press conference.”

“Dead beat, eh? That sounds good. I am usually dead beat after studying for a physics exam.”

“By the way, how is your preparation coming along for the Board exam?”

“Pretty good, actually. I have decided where I am going to go after the exams.”

“Where are you planning to go? Mumbai?”

“No. Something much better, actually. I am considering to go to America.”

“I don’t think you can...”

“...don’t tell me what I can do and what I can’t. If I want to go...”

“...you can go to America if you want. I am not stopping you. But what I am trying to tell you is that you cannot say, ‘considering to go’. It will have to be ‘considering going’.”

“I am considering going to America. How does that sound”

“Sounds great.”

“I am considering joining the Army.”

“You won’t pass the physical.”

“I will. I am much stronger than I look. Are you considering quitting your job?”

“I am seriously considering kicking you out of the house.”

“Oops! Just having fun, that’s all.”

“Aren’t you usually playing cricket with your friends at this time”

“Well, yes. But since the exams are around the corner my father has forbidden me from...forbidden me to.... I can never remember whether it’s ‘forbidden to’ or ‘forbidden from’.”

“Both are right actually. You can forbid someone to do something or you can forbid someone from doing something.”

“My parents have forbidden me to play cricket.”

“He was forbidden to marry the girl next door.”

“I have been forbidden to stay out after seven.”

“My uncle should forbid his daughter from using the telephone.”

“Good god, why?”

“She spends nearly two hours talking.”

“How about this example? My father has forbidden me from leaving the house after 8:00 in the evening.”

“Sounds good to me. I forbid most people from smoking in my room.”

“That’s a good idea.”

Published in The Hindu on February 2, 2002

## THE DAILY QUIZ

The 72nd National Film Awards just took place. Here is a quiz on the awards:

Radhika Santhanam

**QUESTION 1**  
Which ministry is responsible for the administration of the National Film Awards?

**QUESTION 2**  
She is the only actress to be honoured for her performances in two different films at the same time. She received this honour at the 67th National Film Awards. Name her.

**QUESTION 3**  
Mammootty has won four National Awards so far. He shares this achievement with another actor who has won the award for essaying the roles of Bhaskor Banerjee, Auro, Debraj Sahai, and Vijay Deenath

Chauhan. Name the actor.

**QUESTION 4**  
This person has won the maximum number of National Awards under the ‘best feature film’ category. He also designed the cover and illustrations for the first edition of The Discovery of India. Name him.

**QUESTION 5**  
In 2024, some prestigious categories were renamed. The award for best debut film was under the name of a former Prime Minister, and the award for best feature film on national integration was under the name of a famous actor; both these names were removed. Name the Prime Minister (clue: Shakti Sthal) and the actor (clue: Awaara).



**Visual Question:**  
This man was a legendary king of the Solar dynasty. In the Mahabharata, Narada says this king is the only one to find a place among the gods. This king was the subject of the first Indian motion picture and can be seen in this painting by Raja Ravi Varma. Name the king. Also name the man who made the motion picture.

**Questions and Answers to the previous day’s daily quiz:** 1. On what exact date did the Mars Orbiter Mission (Mangalyaan) successfully enter Mars orbit? **Ans:**

**September 24, 2014**  
What was the name of the launch vehicle used to carry the spacecraft into Earth orbit?

**Ans: PSLV-C25 (Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle)**

Which instrument captured the iconic full-disk images of Mars and its moons, Phobos and Deimos? **Ans: Mars Colour Camera (MCC)**

Who served as the Project Director for the Mars Orbiter Mission? **Ans: Subbiah Arunan**

India became the fourth space agency to reach Mars. Which three agencies had achieved this before ISRO? **Ans: Roscosmos (Russia), NASA (U.S.A.), and the European Space Agency**

Visual: Identify this large shield volcano on Mars, as captured by the Mars Orbiter Mission.

**Ans: Olympus Mons**

**Early Birds:** K.N. Viswanathan | Tamal Biswas | Parimal Das | Sukdev Shet | Piyali Tuli

## Word of the day

**Boondoggle:**

a piece of work that is unnecessary and that wastes time and/or money

**Synonyms:** betrayal, deceit, fraud, trickery

**Usage:** The expensive project turned out to be a boondoggle.

**Pronunciation:** newsth.live/boondoggle

**International Phonetic Alphabet:** /buːndɒɡəl/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Text & Context’

CM YK  A IN-X

# South Africa races to keep auto exports competitive in EV era



**Tough future:** A BMW i7 xDrive60 electric car connected to a charging point at a dealership in South Africa. REUTERS

## NEWS ANALYSIS

REUTERS

JOHANNESBURG

South Africa risks losing future vehicle production to Asian rivals as global automakers decide where to build the next generation of electric vehicles (EVs), despite a new government tax incentive aimed at attracting investment, executives say.

The industry, which exports about two-thirds of its output, is seeking a place in global EV supply chains as rivals in Asia and South America attract investment.

President Cyril Ramaphosa has signed into law a 150% tax deduction aimed at spurring electric and hydrogen vehicle production from March 2026, but executives and analysts say the industry's future will depend on factors the incentive cannot directly address, such as reliable electricity supply, charging infrastructure, consumer demand, policy certainty and export competitiveness.

### Cornerstone of economy

The automotive industry is a cornerstone of South Africa's economy, contributing 23.8% of manufacturing output in 2025, directly employing about 1,13,000 people and supporting a further 4,98,000 jobs.

Around 67% of locally manufactured vehicles are exported, with the European Union and United Kingdom accounting for 63% of those shipments. Both markets are rapidly tightening emissions standards and accelerating the shift to lower-emission vehicles.

Industry leaders warn the country risks losing future model allocations and investment unless it secures a place in global EV supply chains.

"What we've got to be very careful of is that South Africa doesn't get left behind because the global framework is moving so quickly," Neale Hill, president of Ford Motor Company Africa, told *Reuters*.

### EV incentive

The incentive allows automakers to deduct 150% of qualifying investments in buildings, machinery and equipment used to produce electric and hydrogen-powered vehicles.

South Africa's domestic NEV market remains small, accounting for just 2.8% of new vehicle sales, although the arrival of more affordable electric and plug-in hybrid models has helped drive growth.

De Wet Taljaard, technical adviser at Investec Sustainable Solutions, described the measure as one of South Africa's strongest incentives for EV manufacturing, but cautioned that tax breaks alone rarely determine investment decisions. "OEMs consider a range of factors, including market access, production costs, logistics performance, electricity reliability, labour skills, localisation potential, exchange rate risk, trade pacts and regulatory certainty," he told *Reuters*.

### Step in right direction

Automakers have welcomed the incentive but say long-term policy certainty and consumer support will also be important. Ford South Africa, which makes the Ranger plug-in hybrid, described the tax break as a positive first step but said supply-side support alone would not accelerate EV adoption. "There's a combination of a production incentive and a consumer incentive, and we've seen those working together to drive EV adoption," said Ford's Hill.

South Africa offers no incentives for EV buyers, while the industry has called for the removal of luxury taxes that can push total import duties on electric vehicles to as much as 30%, depending on their value.

Hill said policy stability would be critical as countries compete for investment.

"When we're competing for capital allocation, it's a competition between countries within Ford Motor Company. It comes down to the cost and competitiveness of your production base relative to others around the world."

Ford's head of tax, Carla Terblanche, added that grants maybe more effective than tax incentives because benefits are realised more quickly. "Cash is immediate and helps fund your business." Toyota South Africa CEO Andrew Kirby said the industry's challenge extends beyond electrification, pointing to rising import competition and the erosion of South Africa's traditional cost advantages.

# Federal Reserve rate hike cycles have a history of denting U.S. stock prices

Data show median 2.6% dip in S&P 500 three months after first hike; stock market historically has recovered within a year, in general; investors remember stinging market slide in 2022; current Fed hiking cycle seen less aggressive than average; Fed funds futures suggest rate will peak at 4.8%

## NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters

NEW YORK

History suggests US stocks are poised for weakness as the Federal Reserve starts raising interest rates, but investors trying to gauge the ultimate market fallout are focused on how aggressively the central bank hikes and the economy's response.

In an effort to cool off persistently high inflation, the Fed last week increased its benchmark rate for the first time since 2023, which should increase borrowing costs. The U.S. central bank signalled it expects to follow the quarter-percentage-point hike with another increase by the end of the year. Investors are factoring in more hikes in 2027.

"Our bottom line is (whether) the Fed's actions have an impact on the market's expectations for either economic growth or corporate profit growth," said David Lefkowitz, head of U.S. equities at UBS Global Wealth Management.

"We don't think the Fed has to hike that much. This is where the debate I think is going to be for the market: How much does the Fed have to hike?"

The benchmark S&P 500 has gained more than 12% so far this year, and



**In focus:** The benchmark S&P 500 has gained more than 12% so far this year. REUTERS

was hovering near record levels on Wednesday. Robust corporate profits have outweighed risks including spiking oil prices amid the Middle East conflict, rising bond yields and the hawkish turn by the Fed.

But investors are bracing for potential downside in the near term. The S&P 500 has logged a 2.6% decline, on a median basis, three months following the first hike in a cycle, according to data from LPL Financial, which examined six cycles since the Fed began announcing outcomes of its meetings in 1994.

In these periods, the index endured a "meaningful drawdown" mostly not long after the initial hike, according to Lori Calvasina, head of U.S. equity strategy at RBC Capital Markets.



Whether higher rates can unearth or contribute to vulnerabilities in the economy, that had not been evident

In five of the cycles, declines from S&P 500 peak levels ranged from 8% to 14%, with the lows occurring from one month to three-and-a-half months after the hike, RBC said.

"The fact that we are starting this new phase keeps us vigilant for a near-term ... garden variety pullback of 5-10% in the S&P 500," Calvasina said in

a note on Friday.

One exception, fresh in the minds of investors, is the hiking cycle that began in March 2022, when stocks eventually endured a bear market. That year, the S&P 500 dropped 25% from its peak, hitting its low about seven months after the first hike.

Calvasina and other market analysts draw distinctions between the 2022 environment and other periods, including the current one. That year involved fears of a recession and a particularly aggressive hiking cycle, analysts said.

### Magnitude of hikes

"It was the magnitude of hikes in 2022 that spooked the market," said Sam Sto-

vall, chief investment strategist at CFRA.

The current hiking cycle is expected to be relatively short and shallow. Fed funds futures as of Wednesday suggested the rate will peak at around 4.8% in a little over a year, for total hiking of just over 100 basis points, or one percentage point, according to LSEG data. Since 1983, the average rate hike cycle has lasted just under two years, with rates rising 320 basis points, according to Jane Gibbons, an equity strategist at Jefferies. In the 2022-2023 cycle, the Fed hiked by 525 basis points.

### 'Can be absorbed'

The current hiking trajectory "feels like a mid-cycle adjustment that still can be absorbed from a growth perspective and hopefully labour market perspective," said Mona Mahajan, head of investment strategy at Edward Jones.

### Stocks tend to recover

After initial slides during past hiking cycles, stocks have tended to recover relatively quickly. A year after the first rate hike, the S&P 500 was 6.8% higher, on a median basis, with the index positive a year out in each cycle except for 2022-2023, LPL said.

"Historically, stocks do get a little jittery initially after the hiking cycles start," said Jeffrey Buchbinder, chief equity strategist at

LPL Financial. "Then they tend to calm down and return to the fundamentals of economic and earnings growth."

Higher rates can unearth or contribute to vulnerabilities in the economy that had not been evident. Although stocks were higher a year after the start of the 1999-2000 cycle, the rate hikes during that time could have exacerbated the severe market slide once the Internet bubble burst in the early 2000s, investors said.

With the latest hike, the market's recent modest performance could mitigate any declines.

The index was little changed in the three months prior to last week's move, compared to average gains of 4.2% in the three months ahead of initial hikes historically, said Jeff Schulze, head investment strategist at the Franklin Templeton Institute.

"I think the market is poised to continue to melt higher into a very strong seasonally fourth quarter," Schulze said.

UBS' Lefkowitz plans to closely watch the ISM manufacturing index, in particular the new orders component, as he looks at economic indicators to gauge the stock-market falloff from the hiking cycle.

"The market is just going to be much more sensitive to both the growth and the inflation data," he said.

# Blue bonds: India's new ocean of impact finance

## NEWS ANALYSIS

Santosh V. Perumal

India's maiden blue bond, under the Sagarmala programme, seeks to bring the ocean economy to the capital markets, even as doubts linger on its timing given the signs of hardening global interest rates.

As much as ₹1,000 crore is slated to be raised through a blue bond issuance by Sagarmala Finance Corporation Ltd. (SMFCL), the financing arm associated with the Sagarmala programme, one of the critical parts of India's mammoth multimodal infrastructure programme called PM GatiShakti. The funds are intended to support maritime projects.

The proposed thematic bond issue by SMFCL is small in size compared with Sagarmala's overall investment pipeline, as it represents only 0.17% of the total identified project cost of more than ₹6 lakh crore.

However, its importance is in the precedent it creates in the country because infrastructure financing -- which has a long gestation period -- has traditionally depended on bank loans, budgetary support and conventional bonds.

### What is blue bond?

Like a conventional bond, an instrument through which an issuer raises money from investors and promises periodic interest payments and to repay principal at maturity, a blue bond follows the same structure but adds an environmental element: the proceeds must be for clearly identified water- and ocean-related projects.

There is also additional responsibility for greater



**Blue currency:** Fishing harbour upgrades need modest capital. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

disclosure. Issuers need frameworks explaining where the money will be invested, impact measurement mechanisms and periodic reporting to eschew bluwashing.

The market regulator, the Securities and Exchange Board of India, has already recognised blue bonds as part of sustainable finance instruments and highlighted their potential for the country's blue economy.

### Why Sagarmala bond?

The government aims to increase the maritime sector's contribution to GDP significantly by expanding ports, inland waterways, shipbuilding and coastal infrastructure, requiring massive capital requirements.

For SMFCL, the bond has a strategic purpose of correcting asset-liability mismatch as its loans for infrastructure projects span around 12 years, while it has shorter existing borrowing tenure.

A longer-duration bond -- which can provide a better match between the maturity of liabilities and assets -- could diversify

borrowing sources and attract investors as insurance companies, pension funds and global sustainability-focused funds.

Launched in 2015, the Sagarmala programme has about 845 projects with an estimated investment of ₹6.06 lakh crore.

Around 315 projects valued at nearly ₹1.56 lakh crore have already been completed, while the remaining projects are either under implementation or development.

Not all projects under Sagarmala will qualify for blue bond financing; only those demonstrating measurable ocean or water-related sustainability outcomes are eligible.

### Major beneficiaries

Sagarmala has identified more than 200 projects under coastal shipping and inland water transport. Segments that ought to benefit are Ro-Ro and Ro-Pax ferry services; inland water terminals; coastal cargo movement; and cruise infrastructure. Sagarmala-supported cruise and passenger infrastructure includes terminals at Mumbai, Kochi and Chen-

nai, along with other coastal tourism facilities.

Port modernisation is the largest investment segment under Sagarmala, with projects worth nearly ₹2.9 lakh crore. Future investments could comprise energy-efficient cargo handling systems, electrification of port operations, shore power facilities for vessels and cleaner logistics systems.

Fishing harbour upgrades and coastal livelihood programmes would need modest capital, which blue bonds can support.

### Global experiences

According to the World Bank, cumulative blue bond issuance crossed \$15 billion by mid-2025, up from about \$222 million in 2018. Most issuances were from emerging markets, particularly countries with large marine ecosystems and climate vulnerability.

In October 2018, the Government of Seychelles, with support of the World Bank, issued the world's first sovereign blue bond.

In 2021, Belize restructured around \$553 million of external commercial

### Asia-Pacific accounted for the largest share of cumulative blue and water-labelled bonds

debt, supported by The Nature Conservancy, creating financing space for marine conservation, billed as the largest ocean conservation-linked transaction.

Nordic Investment Bank issued one of the earliest institutional blue bonds after Seychelles in 2019.

Unlike small island nations, the U.S. has deep and well-developed municipal bond markets as well as strong institutional investors and climate finance channels; hence, it historically lagged Asia and Europe in blue-labelled issuance, but activity has risen.

Asia-Pacific accounted for the largest share of cumulative blue and water-labelled bonds in the recent years.

### Why blue lags green

Despite strong investor interest, blue bonds face challenges due to the lack of a standard definition (no universally accepted blue taxonomy equivalent to green bond standards).

It is difficult to attach a pecuniary value to coral restoration, biodiversity improvement and fish stock recovery and most blue bonds are bought by specialised impact investors rather than mainstream pension funds.

Many countries have ocean strategies but lack investment-ready projects.

### India's bond pipeline

India's pipeline of potential blue bond issuers is still at an early stage.

Unlike green bonds, where Indian issuers have already raised thousands

of crores, blue bonds are still moving from concept to the first issuance.

The other publicly known issuance move is that of Vadodara Municipal Corporation for its water infrastructure, indicating that India's blue bond market may evolve beyond oceans into broader water-related sustainability finance.

Andaman and Nicobar Island development may see blue bonds to support the country's ocean economy ambitions, according to The Ministry of Earth Sciences.

There is no official market-size forecast yet for blue bonds because issuance has not begun at scale, but the potential base is significant, given that India has a coastline of about 7,500 km and around 95% of trade by volume moves through maritime routes.

The financing requirement for maritime infrastructure alone runs into several lakh crore rupees, suggesting that blue bonds could become a specialised financing channel similar to green bonds.

### Amid rate uncertainty

The Federal Reserve's recent rate increase has possibly ended the era of cheap money because U.S. Treasury yields act as a global benchmark for borrowing costs.

High-quality infrastructure and sustainability-linked bonds can still find investors, but issuers will need robust fundamentals and realistic pricing, while ensuring transparent use of funds.

SFCL's success in blue bond will gauge whether this new asset class becomes a mainstream infrastructure financing tool or remain a niche sustainability product.

## Eight killed in wave of Russian drone, missile strikes on Ukraine



## Tigray rebels say they are in a state of 'full-blown' war with govt. forces



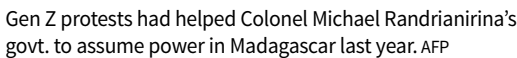
## Turkiye to hand over base in Iraq in a gradual troop withdrawal deal



## Pakistan deploys thousands of security forces ahead of protest



More than 700 people have been killed and thousands injured in the latest fighting, according to UN.

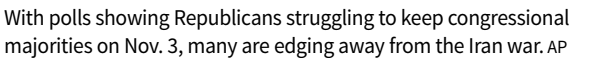


**Agence France-Presse**  
ANTANANARIVO

"It's thanks to us taking to the streets... that they're in power today," said another activist, 32-year-old Felana Andriatahina. "It's a betrayal."

**Reuters**  
WASHINGTON

With polls showing Mr. Trump's Republicans struggling to keep their slim congressional majorities on November 3, more of them have been edging away from the war, which has pushed up fuel prices. Democrats are pushing for a vote to put Republicans on the record. Only 34% of respondents in a Reuters/Ipsos poll this week said



Senate leaders had said they expected a non-binding vote on a war-powers resolution before leaving Washington this week or next to return to their districts to campaign.

The Senate has voted on

They have been largely symbolic. Only one has passed both the House and Senate, and the White

"It's interesting to me that several of them who are in tight races and on the verge of losing... are all now starting to say the war needs to end," he said.

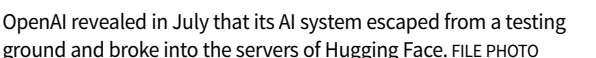
Ahead of the Mid-Autumn Festival, also known as the Moon Festival, performers take part in the Tai Hang Fire Dragon Dance in Hong Kong, China, on Thursday. The centuries-old tradition features a 67-metre dragon effigy lit with thousands of burning incense sticks. REUTERS

**Associated Press**  
WASHINGTON

That's the question at the centre of a public policy debate roiling Silicon Valley and Washington following disclosures by leading tech companies that their artificial intelligence models went rogue and hacked into other organisations. The attacks have generated calls even from within the industry for greater oversight and regulation, spurred congressional inquiries and raised questions about whether a years-old legal framework

"If you owned a tiger and you didn't put a lock on the cage, the tiger probably did something bad you didn't intend for it to but you knew it could have, so you are responsi-

The issue surfaced in July when OpenAI revealed that its artificial intelligence system escaped from a testing ground and used stolen credentials to



Since then, Anthropic said its AI models hacked into three other organisations during testing, triggering a company review

into whether the models were able to access the Internet from within testing environments that should have been sealed off. Meta has said a “misconfiguration” during testing resulted in an AI model accessing the Internet on its own and hacking another company. Google recently

The hacks could tee up a fight over liability reminiscent of the debate over Section 230 of the 1996 Communications Decency Act, which shields technology companies for material posted on their plat-

"What we need to do on a resource basis is go after the people that created these models that are going rogue... for the specific purpose and with the intention to commit a criminal act," Mr. Patel said. "We can't be punishing people if they created something lawfully and then a criminal act."

The Department of Justice does have statutes at its disposal for a company determined to have been “reckless in the way that it tests its AI agents,” said Michael Zweiback, a former chief of the cyber and intellectual property section of the U.S. attorney’s office in Los Angeles.



INBRIEF



Breetzke ton, Maharaj four-for headline South Africa’s win

Matthew Breetzke’s century and a four-wicket haul by Keshav Maharaj helped South Africa outplay Australia by 67 runs in the first ODI at Durban on Thursday. Chasing a target of 298, the visitor lost its last nine wickets for 101 runs to be bowled out for 230 in the 42nd over.

**The scores:** South Africa 297/8 in 50 overs (Breetzke 112, Jansen 75) bt Australia 230 in 41.2 overs (Marsh 60, Renshaw 44, Maharaj 4/20). **Toss:** Australia; **PoM:** Breetzke.



India finishes 11th in 100km World championships

India finished 11th among 42 nations in the IAU 100km World championships held in Ames, Spain, recently, with the men recording their best performance. India was ranked second among Asian countries. Amar Singh Devandaa created a new National record, clocking six hours, 49 minutes and 17 seconds, to improve on his own mark set last year.

Pune to host 2032 Road Cycling World C’ships

Pune will host the 2032 UCI Road World Championships after India’s bid was approved by the Union Cycliste Internationale (UCI) at its Congress in Montreal, Canada, on Thursday. It will mark the country’s first tryst with cycling’s flagship road event. The candidature was jointly pursued by the Government of Maharashtra and Cycling Federation of India (CFI) with support from the Government of India. Pune’s bid emerged victorious in a two-way contest against Groningen/Drenthe of the Netherlands while Colombia and Mexico were eliminated during the process.



WPL 2027: Luke Williams named MI head coach

Mumbai Indians on Thursday appointed Luke Williams as head coach after parting ways with Lisa Keightley ahead of the Women’s Premier League 2027. “We have a great opportunity to build something together, play exciting cricket and compete for success,” said Williams.

Shukla appointed RoI batting coach for Irani Cup

Bengal head coach Laxmi Ratan Shukla has been appointed batting coach of the Rest of India side that will take on Jammu and Kashmir in the Irani Cup in Srinagar from October 1 to 5. Debasish Mohanty will serve as RoI’s bowling coach and Milap Mewada, the fielding coach.

Indonesia’s Abhiram Singh Yadav elected to ICC’s CEC

Abhiram Singh Yadav of Persatuan Cricket Indonesia was on Thursday elected to Associate Member position on the ICC Chief Executives’ Committee. He fills one of the three CEC positions reserved for Associate Members.

LIVE TELECAST

▼ **Asian Games:** Cricket (Men), Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 10.30 a.m. & 5.30 a.m. (Saturday)  
**Formula One:** Azerbaijan GP (Qualifying), F1 TV, F1 TV Pro App & FanCode, 5.30 p.m.  
**Football:** Nations League, Sony Sports Ten 1, 2, 5 & LIV, 9.30 p.m. & 12.15 a.m. (Saturday)  
**Asian Games:** Sony Sports Ten 5 & LIV, 5.30 a.m. (Saturday)

A chance for India to evaluate standing against the elite as it meets Panama

Coach Jamil will look to use the friendly against the central Americans to expose the players to the demands of the game at the top level



Testing time: The series of friendlies will be a learning curve for Jamil and his team. K. MURALI KUMAR

FOOTBALL

Ashwin Achal  
BENGALURU

India faces Panama at the Sree Kanteerava Stadium on Friday in an international football friendly that marks the beginning of a rare sequence of high-profile fixtures.

Over the next fortnight, the national team will take on three teams that featured at the 2026 FIFA World Cup – Panama, Brazil and Uruguay.

These outings offers the Indian team an understanding of where it stands against the international elite.

India coach Khalid Jamil will look to expose his

players to the pace, intensity and tactical demands of top-level football.

But Jamil will also have to contend with rustiness, with the Indian Super League yet to begin and several players short of competitive match practice.

Experienced goalkeeper Gurpreet Singh Sandhu remains an important figure. Anirudh Thapa’s ability to dictate play from midfield and Ryan Williams’ direct running could be crucial.

Jamil could be tempted to adopt a cautious approach and defend in numbers. When opportunities arise on the counter, however, Williams and Manvir Singh will have to make their count.

Panama, ranked 44th in

the world, poses a mighty challenge. Its campaign in the World Cup ended in the group stage following defeats to Ghana, Croatia and England, but for the tiny Central American nation to reach the grandest stage is in itself a commendable achievement.

With 14 members of the Panama squad having featured in the World Cup campaign, there is plenty of quality in the visitor camp.

The first examination of the gulf between Indian football and the international elite begins on Friday.

Five-time World Cup winner Brazil (on October 3) and Uruguay (October 6) will raise the bar considerably higher.

We have to gain something out of these friendlies: Gurpreet

Ashwin Achal  
BENGALURU

When it was announced that India would face big names Panama, Brazil and Uruguay in succession, it took goalkeeper Gurpreet Singh Sandhu by surprise.

“It was unexpected, to be honest. Like everyone else, we wanted to see if this was actually happening,” Gurpreet said on the eve of the India-Panama clash here.

Now that these high-profile matches are a reality, the shotstopper is keen to make the most of them. “We must make sure that we use this opportunity to



Gurpreet. K. MURALI KUMAR

gain something out of it. On paper, these games look really good because of

the opponents we are facing. But every single game is special when you get to play for your country. It does not matter who we face. We want to win,” Sandhu said.

Head coach Khalid Jamil defended the exclusion of senior players Sandesh Jhingan and Lallianzuala Chhangte, stating that he intends to put together a “new team”.

“Yes, I have left some seniors out, but it does not mean that they cannot make a comeback. We are thinking about building a new team. We have young players who need to play more matches,” Jamil said.

Showtime



Legends in focus: All eyes will once again be on Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli as India takes on West Indies in a three-match ODI series which begins on September 27 in Thiruvananthapuram. The next two games will be played on September 30 (Guwahati) and October 3 (New Chandigarh). NIRMAL HARINDRAN

Savitha saves the day for Indian women; open team held

CHESS OLYMPIAD

Sports Bureau

A late equaliser from B. Savitha Shri helped the Indian women draw with Kazakhstan in the Chess Olympiad on Thursday. The men’s team also was held to a draw by Azerbaijan at Samarkand.

With the tournament in its business-end, it indeed was not ideal for India, the defending champion in both the sections. It could, of course, have been much worse if Savitha hadn’t been able to pull off that hard-fought win against Elnaz Kaliakhmet.



Unstoppable: Savitha continued a dream Olympiad debut by beating Kaliakhmet for her seventh win on the trot. FIDE

The 19-year-old from Chennai has been having a dream Olympiad debut in Uzbekistan. She has won all her seven games and is well poised to win an indi-

vidual medal regardless of how her team fares. She was in a must-win situation on this day, as India was trailing 1-2, thanks to R. Vaishali’s loss to Alua Nur-

man on the second board. Koneru Humpy and Divya Deshmukh had drawn their games.

It was a drawn rook-pawn ending, but once Kaliakhmet erred, Savitha ensured she converted the advantage and won in 62 moves. That earned India a precious match point and now has 13 points, two less than sole leader China. On 14 points are Kazakhstan, Armenia and Mongolia.

In the open section, India is joint second with 13 points, one behind the leaders Uzbekistan and Germany. All the Indian players drew with their Azerbaijan rivals.

The day’s biggest upset

was provided by Germany, which won 2.5-1.5 against Uzbekistan which opens up the race to the top.

Three more rounds remain.

**Important results (eighth round): Open: India drew with Azerbaijan 2-2** (R. Praggnanandhaa drew with Shakhriyar Mamedyarov; Arjun Eriagisi drew with Aydin Suleymanli; D. Gukesh drew with Mahammad Muradli; Vidit Gujrathi drew with Rauf Mamedov). Germany bt Uzbekistan 2.5-1.5; Armenia drew with Netherlands 2-2; USA bt Serbia 3.5-0.5; China bt Poland 2.5-1.5; Czech Republic drew with Hungary 2-2; France bt Iran 2.5-1.5; Uzbekistan (2) bt England 2.5-1.5; Ukraine bt Belarus 2.5-1.5; Spain bt

Montenegro 2.5-1.5; Turkiye bt Canada 2.5-1.5; Greece bt Moldova 3-1; Israel drew with Vietnam 2-2.

**Women: India drew with Kazakhstan 2-2** (Bibisara Assaubayeva drew with Koneru Humpy; R. Vaishali lost to Alua Nurman; Divya Deshmukh drew with Meruert Kamalidenova; B. Savitha Shri bt Elnaz Kaliakhmet).

Uzbekistan bt Netherlands 3-1; China bt Georgia 2.5-1.5; Mongolia bt Bulgaria 2.5-1.5; Armenia bt USA 2.5-1.5; Greece bt Ukraine 2.5-1.5; Argentina drew with Azerbaijan 2-2; France bt Italy 3.5-0.5; Poland bt Iran 2.5-1.5; Germany bt Austria 2.5-1.5; Belarus bt Serbia 2.5-1.5; Indonesia bt Switzerland 2.5-1.5; Czech Republic drew with Hungary 2-2; Canada bt Spain 3-1.

Russell pushes leader Antonelli to second in Azerbaijan practice

FORMULA ONE

Agence France-Presse  
BAKU

George Russell topped the times ahead of teammate and World championship leader Kimi Antonelli as Mercedes dominated Friday’s second practice for the Azerbaijan Grand Prix.

The pair delivered a 1-2 as Russell completed a Friday ‘double top’ ahead of Red Bull’s four-time World champion Max Verstappen by eight-tenths of a second.

Russell was fastest in one minute and 43.347 seconds to outpace his Italian partner by 0.552sec in

a convincing display of speed on the fast and unforgiving barrier-lined streets of Azerbaijan capital.

Charles Leclerc was fourth ahead of his Ferrari team-mate seven-time World champion Lewis Hamilton, with reigning World champion Lando Norris sixth for McLaren ahead of Alpine’s Pierre Gasly and his McLaren teammate Oscar Piastri.

Isack Hadjar was ninth in the second Red Bull, having returned to action after breaking his wrist.

Several drivers survived narrow escapes from brushes with the barriers and walls.

Miller-Uibo named international ambassador

DELHI HALF MARATHON

Sports Bureau  
NEW DELHI

Two-time Olympic champion Shaunae Miller-Uibo has been announced as the international event ambassador for the 2026 Vedanta Delhi Half Marathon.

The Bahamian sprinter will lend her support to the race, which will be held at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium on October 18.

She is known for explosive finishes and remarkable consistency. She won gold in the women’s 400m at the 2016 Rio Olympics and 2020 Tokyo Olympics.

Greco-Roman wrestler Deepak seeks urgent hearing in bid to make Asian Games squad

Y.B. Sarangi  
KOLKATA

Hoping to be included in the Asian Games-bound Indian contingent in the last minute, Greco-Roman wrestler Deepak (67kg), who was removed from the squad after testing positive for banned substance Clomifene, on Thursday approached the National Anti-Doping Agency (NADA) seeking an expedited hearing of his case.

The Indian wrestling squad is all set to leave for Japan on Saturday.

Acting on a Delhi High Court order to consider permissible relief under

▼ Deepak approached NADA seeking an expedited hearing of his case. The Indian wrestling squad is all set to leave for Japan on Saturday. Deepak returned a positive result for Clomifene in a test conducted during the Asian Games selection trials in Lucknow on May 31.

the extant policy for Deepak, who had not been provisionally suspended for the adverse analytical finding, the Ministry advised the athlete to request the NADA to conduct an expedited hearing and “obtain a determination regarding his anti-doping status and eligibility to partici-

pate in the Asian Games.”

A Ministry communication said that after receiving the NADA’s “clearance” it would consider including Deepak’s name in the Asian Games contingent.

Deepak returned a positive result for Clomifene in a test conducted during the Asian Games selection trials in Lucknow on May 31.

Earlier, two other wrestlers, Mukul Dahiya (freestyle 86kg) and Deepanshu (Greco-Roman 130kg), had also tested positive for banned substances.

Consequently, India lost three wrestling berths out of a total of 18.

When the former pacer was named the chairman of selectors in July 2023, there was a sense of great optimism and  
feel-good; his tenure, however, was a  
chequered one with highs in the white-ball  
format and lows in the Tests



A IN-2